

Singapore Government

- **Morality VS Pragmatism:** Politicians have the moral duty to protect the disadvantaged and marginalised in society. Being overly pragmatic will only **alienate leaders from the rest of society**, as it would lead to a **lack of empathy and sensitivity to the needs of the people**. This need to prioritise morality over pragmatism in politics is demonstrated in Singapore, where the government's pragmatic approach towards growth has always been evident. The government allocates a mere 16% to social welfare in Singapore, which is well below the OECD average, and continually reminds Singaporeans that it is this practical approach to governance that is responsible for the country's wealth and prosperity. However, in recent years, citizens have been more critical of this pragmatic approach, which they believe is morally unjustified as it fails to help the less fortunate and needy in the country. *They expressed their **displeasure in the 2011 elections**, where the PAP received its lowest share of votes, 60.14%, since independence. This prompted the government to swiftly restructure their policies, and roll out schemes like the **\$8 billion Pioneer Generation Package** to help needy elderly in the country. Despite not contributing to the economy and draining government resources, such as schemes to help the needy were **lauded by Singaporeans** as ethical and morally responsible, culminating in a resurgence of support for PAP in the 2015 elections, where they won 69.84% of the votes.* A politician's job does not simply revolve around ensuring continued economic success for the country. It also involves showing **concern and addressing the needs of the people**, even if it compromises the nation's growth or puts a strain on the nation's coffers. Morality can be said to be more important than pragmatism in politics, as hard-headed politicians without a sense of moral duty to the people will fail to earn the mandate and respect from the electorate, regardless of their successes in governance.

- **Opposition does not serve as an effective check and balance:** In the 2015 Singapore General Election, PAP won resoundingly with 69.9% of the votes and 83 out of 89 available seats in parliament. The PAP's overwhelming victory showed that it has **won back the trust of the populace** after the 2011 General Elections after changing its **authoritative approach to governance to one that is more responsive to the needs of the citizens**. As a result, the **opposition parties have been unsuccessful in capitalising on grievances concerning issues** such as immigration and rising costs of living. Furthermore, the opposition parties won less seats than the previous GE despite contesting for more. This reveals the general feeling that the opposition **can no longer act as merely a check on the PAP-dominated government**. Instead, it has to **provide alternative policies**. *For example, the Workers' Party handling of the AHPETC saga has also planted **doubts in the electorate** as to their character and whether they are ready to assume greater responsibilities*. This incident has clearly **undermined the credentials of the opposition**.
- **Willingness to respond to the needs of the people:** Politicians are more willing to listen to the grievances of their people and act upon their feedback. *The significant increase in the proportion of votes for the People's Action Party from 60.14% in 2011 to 69.9% in the 2015 General Elections can be **attributed to the ruling party's willingness to react rapidly to the concerns of the populace***. New houses were built, MRT lines were proposed and immigration was tightened significantly within a few years. It is clear that the government has taken the feedback of their people seriously and rapidly responded to their grievances and needs. Despite an **increasingly demanding electorate**, people are not blind to the **sincerity of the government** in their attempts to improve and deliver their promises. The people of successful governments recognise their leaders' attempts at responding to their requests in a bid to **placate them**, thus reciprocate by lending their support to such genuine leadership, whose primary interest lies in the will of the people.

Lee Kuan Yew's leadership

- **Machiavellian leadership stance:** *"I have never been over concerned or obsessed with opinion polls or popularity polls. I think a leader who is, is a weak leader. Between being loved and being feared, I have always believed that Machiavelli was right. If nobody is afraid of me, I'm meaningless."* This was a quote by Lee Kuan Yew in *The Singapore Story: Memoirs of Lee Kuan Yew* in 1997. The **Machiavellian leadership stance** is used to characterise a strong ruler who is not afraid of being harsh to those around him. More than any other quotes, perhaps, **this one addresses the persona of Lee Kuan Yew the most.** He was **not afraid to call a spade, a spade** - to be blunt yet also often truthful in ways that will not be termed politically correct today. In doing so, he offended many, often at times when it became a clash of East and West - of Western democratic values as compared to a 'tempered democracy' that is more suitable for Asia. *Over the years, he expounded this issue many times, having done so as early as 1971, when he addressed The General Assembly of the International Press Institute at Helsinki. He believes that the "freedom of the press, freedom of the news media, must be* **subordinated to the overriding needs of the integrity of Singapore, and to the primacy of purpose of an elected government.** Over the years, his no-nonsense approach has gained him both admirers as well as detractors.
- **Foresight:** All would be for naught, if a 'skillful orator' and leader does not have foresight. It is this foresight that has enable LKY to anticipate problems and to get solutions in place, so that the problems can be countered early on before they get more serious. Admittedly, a skillful political orator has very important social significance because he is able to win the hearts and minds of his people. However, the other crucial factor is that with the addition of foresight will make sure that he also has the ability to anticipate other situations to temper his speeches. Finally, the foresight must **translate to tangibles.** For example, the ability to spot problems must be coupled with the willingness to tackle them. *LKY had the strong conviction that there is an imperative need to have minority representation in parliament so that "two Chinese with one minority-race*

candidate in one constituency of three people could be tailored in such a way that you have a fair representation of minorities in Parliament”.

- **Use of fear in the formative years of nationhood:** From the inception of Singapore's independence - when it was expelled from Malaysia - the ideas of '**vulnerability**' and '**survival**' were used to justify LKY's decisions. He promoted the idea that Singapore had to have a strong armed forces, requiring national service in 1967, to protect itself as a nation surrounded by the perceived threat of its Malay neighbours. The enemies outside were matched by those inside, who had to be displaced and in some cases detained. *Among the most controversial were the arrests of men labelled as communists in the **Operation Coldstore of 1963 and Operation Spectrum of 1987** that targeted social activists who promoted greater social equality and were seen as challenging LKY's PAP authority.* Many others from opposition politics, business to academia faced the wrath for challenging and questioning LKY, his PAP and the politicised decisions of its institutions, castigated in the government controlled media, removed from position, forced to live in exile and, in some cases, sued and bankrupted. In a relatively small city- state, **it did not take much to instill a political culture of fear by making a few examples.**
- **Fear not enough to stay in power:** The use of rhetoric, especially in a controlled media can be a very effective means of inculcating in people, a common way of seeing. The whole rhetoric constantly, of '**vulnerability**' and '**survival**' throughout Singapore's formative years has stayed and formed very **strong images** in the **psyche of Singaporeans**. Coupled with the draconian use of law in the early years to arrest dissenters, and a certain 'official' narrative that has been constantly emphasised, brought out to air, and updated in the controlled traditional media, it has a very powerful impact and significance upon the whole history and thinking of the people, making people more cautious and through the years, disinterested in anything deemed 'political', including partaking in civil society. Such attitudes and disinterest is **not conducive to the long- term development of society** because many ordinary people will tend to

shy away from participating in civil society, leaving it open to extremes from both spectrums. In the **heyday of Singapore's economic miracle**, the LKY PAP government worked to **win over the trust** of its people. *It did so by providing for the basic welfare of its citizens, with an impressive housing program, affordable food prices, a living wage, job security, safety, education and opportunity.* This involved the hard work of LKY's founding team of PAP cadre, as well as the sacrifice of ordinary Singaporeans. It also reflected the wise realisation of LKY that fear was not enough to stay in power. There needed to be a **healthy balance of deliverables**. LKY's success story is elevating many diverse people from relative poverty to prosperity in less than a generation has very powerful economic significance, which often **overrides other political setbacks**, thus laying a strong foundation for a well-accepted pragmatist mindset amongst Singaporeans today.

- **Courage to go against populist sentiments:** Singapore's founding fathers believe that good leaders **need to have to courage to say NO**, and to stand firm, in order to take unpopular policies through. This is because unpopular policies often start off initial painful processes that no citizens likes, for example, involving sacrifice on the citizens' part, like belt-tightening measures. However, if s strong leader carries on the '**tough medicine**' and ignores the cries (at least for the crucial years), psychologically it gives both the leader and his people a **certain perspective** and image of him, and if he delivers economically, it then becomes a powerful political image and tool that he can use later. *"Only those count and matter who have the courage of their conviction to stick up and stand up for what they believe in, for their people, their country, regardless of what happens to them."* - LKY on what he has said about standing up for what one believes in, instead of **pandering to populist demands**.

Preservation of Cultural Sites

- **Sacrifices made for development:** Singapore, being a land-scarce nation, will have to make sacrifices in order to **develop modern infrastructure to suit the needs of today's society**. Singapore is one of the most densely population nations in the world, with land area of 719.1 square km, and population density of 7697 per square km. With Singapore projecting its population to swell by a third over the next two decades, this physical constraint would make land constraints in Singapore a growing problem. Thus, the goal of proper land usage is a pertinent issue in the making of development plans in Singapore. *The **Bukit Brown Cemetery** is regarded as an important cultural site in Singapore, being touted as the "Living Museum of History and Heritage". In a city where many buildings are brand new, **cemeteries are a rare link to the past**. In particular, the custom of visiting and worshipping at an ancestor's tomb - an integral aspect of Chinese culture - is one which is often practised at cemeteries. The LTA of Singapore had undertaken a project to build a four-lane road across Bukit Brown Cemetery in the 4th quarter of 2013, which would lead to the exhumation of 5000 graves. The exhumation were viewed as **inevitable in the light of Singapore's land limitation**, as authorities said digging up Bukit Brown for the road will ease congestion from the Pan Island Expressway, the first step towards further development of the area. The Ministry of National Development (MND) is also considering converting all of Bukit Brown into housing by 2030. From this, it can be seen that **such necessary evils are inevitable** - that the goal of preservation of cultural sites may sometimes **be sacrificed in favour of national development**, especially in the light of Singapore's physical constraints.*

- **Advocates who want to preserve cultural sites:** There are groups amongst our society that continue to **advocate the mission of safeguarding our heritage and to lobby against the destruction of cultural sites for development.** *Many non-profit conservation organisations, such as the Nature Society (Singapore), the Singapore Heritage Society, SOS Bukit Brown, raised their **discontentment** with the government's move in an effort to save Bukit Brown from going down a similar path as other cemeteries.* As a response to the public backlash, the government announced that one-third of the new road cutting through Bukit Brown cemetery would be a bridge 10m above ground. This would reduce the number of graves affected to 3764. As such, the preservation of cultural sites in Singapore may not necessarily lose out to development, as there are groups firm in their support of conservation, who serve as constant reminders to the government not to unduly sacrifice cultural sites for progress.
- **Social development in our diverse society:** The preservation of cultural sites is considered **social development in a multi-racial and multi-religious society** like Singapore, as it ensures that the **past historical baggage will not threaten the social fabric** of our nation. Budget 2013 concluded by highlighting the importance of building a shared culture and engaged community through a shared heritage. *To celebrate our diverse heritage, \$62 million will be invested over five years to help museums build collections.* This shows that the government is investing resources and effort in preserving our heritage as part of Singapore's developmental plans. *Speaking at the launch of the Singapore Heritage Fest 2013, PM Lee noted that Singaporeans value not only economic progress but also cultural development. "Our heritage is something that belongs to every Singaporean, which each of us can contribute to help preserve, individually and collectively.* The racial riots and Maria Hertogh riots in the 1950s have enabled Singaporeans to witness the potential consequences of conflicts among different racial and religious groups. These riots arose as a result of a

failure to understand and respect differing cultures. It is thus essential to Singapore to retain significant landmarks **representing the different communities**, as a **mark of recognition and respect for each community** in Singapore. Only through the preservation of our multiracial heritage can we ensure social harmony is attained. The conservation of cultural sites in Singapore is an important way for us to conserve and protect our unique heritage. **Heritage anchors our sense of place and identity** and enables a nation to **adapt and to progress** as the world changes. Without recognising, acknowledging and conserving each race and religion heritage, it is highly unlikely that we will be able to **sustain long-term development** due to the **social implications** that a failure to conserve culture would bring about.

- **Integrating heritage with development:** Cultural sites such as Chinatown, Little India and Kampong Glam, are symbols of our multiracial society which is unique to Singapore. These sites are representative of the different races in Singapore, allowing the various cultures to flourish without inhibition. This aspect is distinctive to our society, and is also one of the main pull factors for our tourism industry. These heritage sites are **popular tourist destinations**, which help to **generate revenue** for the industry, which then contributes to economic growth and progress for our country. *Even in the case of Bukit Brown Cemetery, conservationists have argued that Singaporeans should not always be required to choose between preserving cemeteries and the country's development. Citing the example of how cemeteries in other cities such as Kuala Lumpur have been converted to heritage parks, it has been said that alternative solutions can always be found, allowing Singapore to* **continue advancing while also preserving its history**. Thus, it is possible for the conservation of our heritage to support development, **attaining both goals without any concessions**. In this case, preserving our cultural sites, instead of losing out to development, actually serves to expedite progress. *As what PM Lee mentioned in his speech for the 20th Heritage Centre Anniversary, "We must celebrate our heritage, look back and appreciate how far we have come. At the same time, look forward and write new chapters of the Singapore story together. That way, Singapore will continue to thrive, and we will offer a brighter future for our children and for many*

generations to come.” The importance of **integrating heritage with development** is one that the government continually strives to highlight. Crucial to the goal of conservation of heritage would be to ensure that cultural sites in Singapore are retained, to serve as indicators of our nation’s unique landscape.

Media

- **Freedom of expression being exploited:** Freedom of expression is the right of an individual to speak up as a counterweight to possible dictators and the abuse of power by those who have it. The media, which **serves as the fourth estate**, is expected to check the power of governments through the spreading of information to fight ignorance and justice. Some forms of media, especially traditional media, have taken this freedom to extremes where the **majority tyrannise minority groups** by focusing on negative stereotypes. While this is the tradition in more liberal democracies, things get more complicated in societies which do not have such a tradition and have a history fraught with possibly violent discord. In Singapore, which is **racially and religiously diverse with conservative neighbouring countries**, it is necessary for the media in Singapore to be mindful and sensitive to different racial and religious groups. While **traditional forms of media have been largely governed by strict censorship and control** by editors and the authorities, **social media, though its democratized form, has allowed individuals to voice their frustrations.** *This has led to some making sweeping statements against religious groups such as Muslims, and members of the Malay community, usually by members of the majority Chinese community. This animosity has extended to other minority groups such as migrants from China, the Indian community and the LGBT community. In 2012, Amy Cheong, a former National Trades Union Congress employee, was condemned online for posting racist comments, with the policy issuing a stern warning to her as well. In 2014, British expatriate Anton Casey drew a vocal and angry response from the Singaporean public when he posted derogatory comments on Facebook about the public transport system which eventually caused him to lose his job and leave the country.* Given our history of violent racial conflicts and geopolitics, it is extremely important to not incite emotions and sensitivities. Furthermore, given the **pragmatic nature** of the Singapore society, and the constant desire for stability, such sweeping

statements are not productive and may push back any form of progress. Given Singapore's **geopolitical situation and history**, the enforcement of the Sedition Act and the Religious Harmony Act has been effective in keeping the peace and ensuring the respect of all segments of the diverse Singapore society.

- **Increasing number of alternative media platforms:** In Singapore, the media has been traditionally tightly controlled by the authorities. The **rise of social media** has led to less control of the content being published although the media has been **traditionally and tightly controlled by the authorities** in Singapore. *Numerous blogs such as The Online Citizen and Temasek Review are anti-government views which are fairly popular in Singapore, with a large number of people getting their news solely from online avenues.* With such a connected society like Singapore and with a largely **unfettered access to the Internet**, it would be almost impossible for any standardised regulation or code to be followed or enforced. Most Singaporeans with internet access would be free to read the views of anyone around the world.
- **Distrust of Singapore's media platforms:** There is a **general distrust of established media sources** in Singapore since most views stated in traditional media were very much pro-PAP until the general elections in 2006. The **rise of social media has forced the traditional media to be more objective** and be more reflective of the diverse views in society. There is an **increasing awareness** by traditional media to offer **more balanced views in society**. Even pro-government views are **tempered with more objectivity and chest-thumping**. This is also due to Singaporeans travelling and studying overseas. With such access to alternative views, it would be foolhardy for anyone to limit their views. Having a variety is also in line with the MOE's push towards critical thinking rather than rote learning. In order to function in today's complex world, Singaporeans need to be able to process the information and evaluate it, rather than blindly believe.

- **Power of social media:** *In May 2014, a blogger, Roy Ngerng was sued by PM Lee Hsien Loong for an article he had written, as part of a series about the CPF in his blog, 'The Heart Truths'. When the lawsuit came, he launched an appeal in various **social media sites**, to raise funds for his legal and court fees, which he had estimated to be some \$70,000. However, **within 4 days** of the appeal, the target was reached, and at the end of the appeal, more than \$100,000 was raised for his legal fund. The sheer speed at which Roy Ngerng managed to hit his \$70,000 target - in a matter of 4 days - showed how powerful social media can be. The immediacy and the **viral nature of social media** has put outmoded strategies (such as suing) at a disadvantage. The power of social media, even of only for psychological means, is strong. Many who donated only a small sum of money had even sent him emails to say that what they give is just a token amount but it is given from their hearts. Hence the advent of social media has led to even greater political implications as the Roy Ngerng incident was seen as a case of "winning the battle but losing the war".*

- **Power of consumer choice in the media industry:** *In today's commercial world, the media has to **answer to its customers who pay for what they want to see**. The **power of choice lies with the viewer-consumer**. With the digital and new media, readers and views of media sources are no longer **held hostage by the media networks** within their nations. There is **wide access to alternative choices**. Singaporeans who are disgruntled with the coverage of The Straits Times, for example, no longer have to subscribe to the paper if its coverage does not live up to expectations. *There are social blogs whose writers do not have to kowtow to the establishment and therefore can present views that offer fresh perspectives on issues. Example such as the Online Citizen is a credible online news source that can rival the Straits Times in its coverage of local issues. Similarly, the **discontent with free-to-air television** has given rise to a **shift of preferences to alternatives** like cable channels, downloadable television episodes on iTunes and websites that stream television shows and movies.* With such a **discerning and demanding public**, media entities that do not fulfill their obligations to society **do so at their own peril**.*

- **Trend of trivialisation and tabloidisation of the newspapers:** In the homogenisation of news reports, where the numerous media producers end up serving the consumers with standard fare. News network affiliates would use the same report as parent networks because it would mean cost savings to the smaller media networks. While this does allow the smaller networks to save costs, it then creates a very **generic report of the event with local flavour that leads to the lack of diversity in interpretation.** News consumers that end up with this standard fare criticise that the coverage is not made specific and relevant to them. *When Prince William wedded Kate Middleton in 2011, the local press filled pages and pages of column space with news that did not affect Singaporeans a great deal, and disregarded what was more pertinent locally.*

- **Unreliability of news reports:** Many newspapers, rather than abiding by the high journalistic practices in the past, are increasingly **sacrificing high quality media content to reduce costs**. Technology and high competition between media giants have led to budget cuts in news and resource gathering. This has resulted in foreign correspondents being expected to cover larger areas of the globe, causing them to lose their specialist expertise. The foreign correspondents, with little time to understand the background of the issues they are covering, often resort to **high emotional first-hand accounts** of the news, and readers are often none the wiser with regards to the underlying implications of the issues involved. *One such example is The Straits Times US desk was staffed by Singaporeans living in the United States who had an outsider's understanding of Washington and its politics.* This meant that the coverage and analysis of political news from the USA **lacked the depth and the understanding** that the local media giants like The Washington Post and The New York Times possess. The reporting of the news was mediocre and it had led to many readers turning to American coverage of the issues rather than **relying on The Straits Times' take on them**. It leads to the **integrity and quality** of the paper being called into question because the public feels that the media is **more concerned about cutting cost than educating the public** on what is happening around the world.

Electorate

- **Increasingly vocal and bold electorate:** *Both 2013 and 2014 saw a series of gatherings in Hong Lim Park, which attracted an increasing number of participants. In 2013, the gatherings started with the "Say No to 6.9 million" in opposition of the government's Population White Paper on Immigration. In 2014, there was a series of protests for the government to "Return our CPF".* From these public gatherings, it shows how **vocal the public were** and how they **did not bother to hide their anger and dissatisfaction with the government policies by openly carrying very critical placards**. It was distinctive from both protests that Singaporeans are unafraid to be seen carrying critical placards,

many of whom, boldly and proudly showed their faces, and allowed photographers from both the mainstream media as well as alternative media to photograph and film them and to post videos on social media. There is no doubt that this new “boldness” and new-found voice is a political awakening of sorts and even if it is not a mass protest in the style of Western countries, it is still a very significant one and one that is **set to have increasingly important political implications for the PAP government**. Politically, there are grave implications for the ruling party because it implies that policies of the ruling party are not working as well as they should and a significant number of the population is falling into the cracks. Most importantly, it means that a key sector of people feel so **short-changed** that they would even **risk protesting and openly showing their dissatisfaction** in a country that normally fears going against the government.

- **More educated electorate:** Even when politicians have delivered, their performance are unable to match the expectations of the people, because an increasingly educated electorate **armed with the advent of social media** is unafraid to **vocally express embitterment against their government**. People have far higher expectations of politicians nowadays, as they demand a higher standard of living than before. Trends of consumerism and globalisation has made life more accessible and cosmopolitan, thus people expect a better prospect for their future. With a **higher literacy rate in Singapore today**, as compared to her **tumultuous formative years after independence**, the better-educated population are able to **discern the nuances of government policies** for themselves with a greater sense of judgement. In the past, the populace barely questioned the hugely pragmatic and constrictive policies initiated by the government, such as the Stop at Two childbirth control policy. Yet in today’s context, the government has to adopt an approach with more ‘heart’ in order to connect with the population. The **discontent with the ruling party** was made exigently clear during the 2011 General Election where the opposition won a Group Representative Constituency (GRC) for the first time. An electorate that is better educated is able to make **more informed decisions and critical evaluations of the**

policies proposed by the government. They are not simply obedient and concede to the recommendations of their political leaders since they demand better living standards, rendering the task **of sustaining electoral support to be more challenging** than ever before.

LGBT - Conservatives vs Liberals

- **More liberal society:** The Singapore society is increasingly becoming more liberal and this can be seen from the **“Tango Makes Three” controversy**. *In July 2014, 3 books were removed from the children’s section of the National Library because of a complaint by a member of the public that their contents promote ‘unconventional families’. One of the books “And Tango Makes Three” is a story of 2 male penguins who were companions and nurtured an egg that hatched into a baby penguin. The NLB’s removal of the books received a lot of flak, with many parents and liberal Singaporeans saying that the **division was so arbitrary** and questioning how can books be removed by a mere dint of just one complaint.* In addition, there is also increasing endorsement of the **Pink Dot event** each year that celebrates the LGBT community, with parents bringing even their young children there, to revel in the carnival festival, and encountering same-sex couples. The Pink Dot event has been getting larger and larger, which in itself is a politically significant phenomenon, as interest groups fight to be heard and fight for their rights to be included in society. This issue has shown that increasingly, many younger parents are **more tolerant and liberal about accepting alternative lifestyles and values in society**. These parents are prepared to explain these alternative behavioural modes to their young children.

- **Government ensuring that all views are heard:** a good government has to tread a fine line in ensuring that all views are heard and all individuals are represented while maintaining social cohesion and stability. As countries become **more diverse and open** due to the **forces of globalisation and the openness of media sources**, there is bound to be a clash of ideas and values at some point. However, social media also has the tendency to **amplify the vocal minority, while silencing moderates who might be incentivised enough to offer an alternate point of view**. *In conservative countries like Singapore, there has been a recent backlash against people who have allied themselves with the lesbian, gay, bisexual and transgender communities. Conflicts between these two camps include flame wars on social media, demonstrations and the banning of literary texts.* In Singapore, while there is a perceived majority who are still extremely conservative and do not support the LGBT movement but who also adopt the “live and let live” mentality, the governments have **decided to engage both vocal minority groups who inhabit extreme ends of the spectrum to agree to disagree and engage in debate within acceptable social parameters.**

Self Restraint

- **Religious harmony:** Within multi-racial societies, there are bound to be many cultural differences. Self-restraint, in the form of tolerance and understanding, is needed so as to prevent these cultural differences from escalating into social conflicts. *Singapore has done well in this aspect, teaching children from young to treat everyone, regardless of race or religion, with equal amount of respect and understanding. This is particularly prominent in our social studies lessons and textbooks, where we implore the importance of restraint and understanding in maintaining religious and cultural harmony in a multi-racial fabric.* In comparison, the lack of tolerance of differences between Muslims and Buddhists in Southern Thailand and Myanmar in particular has led to unceasing violence and riots, which are a **vast contrast to the peace in Singapore**. This goes to demonstrate that self-restraint in respecting one’s personal space plays an important role in

minimising violence and conflict. Self-restraint **promotes religious harmony both on an individual and national level**. On an individual level, self-restraint can better help one understand **the cultural and oddities of an opposite race of culture**, and to expand one's horizon and worldly views as an individual. This will in turn promote racial understanding and harmony. On a national level, self-restraint can help promote harmony within a country, **and to drive the country forward with racial harmony and strength as a cohesive and nationalistic ideal**. This will in turn improve intra-national relations and drive economic growth.

- **Asian values:** In Singapore, where we are exposed to the Asian culture, there is a **greater emphasis on traditional values**, self-restraint may be viewed as a positive value as it inculcates character growth and patience. This would in turn allow us to make informed and rational decisions which are the basis of many Asian traditions. However, self-restraint, in many instances is purely down to a matter of moderation as too much self-restraint may stifle creativity.

Political Apathy

- **Lack of checks and balances:** Political apathy is dangerous because of the **potential dangers of abuse and harshness** of a government without the necessary checks and balances in place. A lack of checks and balances might lead to a **lack of transparency and accountability** and hence the WP's call for a 'co-driver'. Political apathy in Singapore leads to important issues being glossed over. *For example, the growing Gini Coefficient and the needs of those less fortunate and ignored by society.*
- **Achieve success despite political apathy:** It is acceptable to be politically apathetic because most of the scientific and economic breakthroughs and leaps were made by individuals who focused on doing their jobs well. This is highly relevant to Singapore because it can be said that Singapore is currently successful because *throughout the 1960s to the early 1990s, Singaporeans were politically disinterested and left the governing of the country totally to elected*

office-bearers. They went about their lives working for themselves and working in their individual capacities and thus helping the country. It is acknowledged that **they have helped to make Singapore the success it is now**. In turn, the PAP government had a **strong mandate** for its policies which so far have been beneficial to Singapore, allowing the citizens to leave the governing of the country in the capable hands of the leaders who proved efficient and trustworthy.

- **Too much dependence on the government:** While apathy has had a positive role, it may not be that beneficial for Singapore in the future. There are many forces and challenges that we face as a society. **Excessive dependence** is a detrimental consequence of political apathy in Singapore. Singaporeans are used to having the **authorities to solve all our problems**. Given the rising costs of the many challenges we face, and the increasingly ever changing nature of the world, new solutions must be found. Singapore is currently facing challenges such as an **ageing population, increasing diversity** in terms of different interest groups, **keeping relevant in today's world**, and increasing **inequality**. It is therefore necessary for citizens to be more proactive in being involved in finding solutions to problems in society.

- **Negativities of being politically active:** Singapore is becoming **more diverse with different values and beliefs systems**. The increasing sense of religiosity in Singapore has led to many clashes and conflicts, such as between the conservative and more liberal members of society in terms of lifestyle choices, practices and belief systems. Being too **politically active** can be problematic, where boundaries regarding decisions made in private lives can be crossed. One danger when citizens are politically active is that they **seek empowerment** in order to make sure that their values and opinions prevail over other equally valid positions. *For example, the AWARE saga when a group of conservative Christians tried to muscle their way into the organisation because they disagreed with AWARE's position on homosexuality, premarital sex and the need for teenagers to know about birth control.* In this sense, a **secular society like Singapore** was in danger of being made religious, thus **disenfranchising other groups of Singaporeans**. In a **diverse society like Singapore** surrounded by Muslim nations, it is therefore of **paramount importance** to ensure that views are respected and accountability is ensured. While it is **heavy-handed and flies in the face of the freedom of expression** and assembly guaranteed in our constitution, the **Sedition Act and the Maintenance of Religious Harmony Act** are crucial in ensuring stability in Singapore. While it is important to have OB markers, a key way to ensure **greater understanding and acceptance** is to engage one another in a **mature, measured and objective manner**.

Image

- **Importance of image to a leader:** Possessing a favourable image **allows one to earn support and popularity**. In an increasingly open and democratic world, it is crucial to develop a promising image of one's character in order to **gain support from the masses**. Since most leaders are selected through voting, the prominent figures must first be able to promote his strengths and persuade his

followers to choose him amongst all his contenders. Leaders, such as political rivals campaigning during the GE and student leaders during the elections for Student Council or CCA Executive Committees, have to build up a positive image. Once a leader's image is tarnished, he would lose popular support and will be unable to carry out his plans designed for the public. *For instance, the previous Members of Parliament of Hougang and Punggol-East, Yaw Shin Leong and Michael Palmer respectively, were expelled from their respective duties due to indiscretion in their private lives.* Therefore, in order for one's career to advance, especially when one is under the attention of the public, one has to preserve an image **characterised by highly desirable values**. Most importantly, one's character has to be **morally acceptable** and **condoned by social rules and norms**.

- **Image of a country to foreigners:** In the 21st century characterised by the **heavy emphasis on business and economic development**, possessing an image with state-of-the-art infrastructure is important to attract foreign direct investment. This is evident in many developed countries that have undergone urban renewal. *In Singapore, the continuous development of Marina Bay with the Singapore Flyer, Gardens by the Bay, Marina Bay Sands resort, Marina Coastal Expressway and the Marina Barrage are all attempts at improving the image of our Central Business District (CBD).* The CBD has to be portrayed as a flourishing area of enterprise that is characterised by technologically advanced facilities, with an even mix of leisure and greenery, reinforcing Singapore's image as a first class business hub as well as Garden City. In the case of individual firms, having a reputable, established brand is crucial for sustained growth in business. *For example, renowned brands such as the Singapore Airlines, Old Chang Kee, and even the National University of Singapore that is ranked as Asia's top university have a long established reputation that puts them at an advantage against smaller businesses and competitors.* Since **export-oriented countries like Singapore** are so heavily reliant on the external sector for sustainable economic growth, much effort must be placed in maintaining this favourable image to ensure **the continuous flows of incomes and investment which form the basis of our economy**. Even though such efforts imply the **superficiality of economic pragmatism**, countries like Singapore have no choice but to emphasise on creating an image on an advantageous environment to attract foreigners for our survival.

- **National defence:** An aggressive image is sometimes required for **self-defense against adversaries**. Small countries such as Singapore must appear strong in order to **deter potential enemies** from attacking them. This is the reason why military developments and investments in arms are sometimes publicised to **intentionally create awareness in the region** that Singapore is not a vulnerable party to be trifled with. *For example, Singapore announced that it has recently bought the Gulfstream 550 Airborne Early Warning aircraft to deal with airborne threats.* One only has to **give the impression** that one is strong **as an act of deterrence against possible adversaries**, even if the reality differs from what it appears on the surface. Hence, image is important because it is the first indication of the ability of a country **to defend itself**. Although a first impression could merely be a concealment of something weaker underneath, it is still undeniably important since it forces an opponent to **think judiciously** and not take any rash steps that could potentially jeopardise its own safety.
- **Superficial image to meet society's expectations:** The need to maintain an image could sometimes restrict one's freedom and desires. In a **pragmatic and superficial society**, where one's social standing is determined by one's possessions, career and wealth, having to maintain a favourable, higher-middle class image could actually evoke unhappiness as a result of the lack of fulfillment of one's personal goals. In local literature, such as Simon Tay's short stories *My Cousin Tim* and *Drive*, the **superficial competition and constrictions** faced in one's career and life goals faced by those who conform and succumb to society's expectations and standards is criticised. **Image is actually a social construct**. This means that the ideal front of a person, and the **desirable trait and characteristics, are all defined by social norms**. Due to the pressures **exerted by society**, the pressure to maintain this image forms a **conflict with one's individuality**. Although there is a risk, cost or penalty when one goes against social norms, sometimes it really is more advantageous to seek **one's personal goals** when one follows his true passion, without taking excessive heed of what society or others think of them. Thus, an image suited to

society's expectations may not necessarily benefit the individual personal growth and aspirations.

- **Hypocrisy of a too-ideal image:** When products do not possess the quality exhibited in advertisements, consumers will feel like they are deceived by profit-making firms. Similarly, political figures or organisations could face criticism from the public when one's behaviour is not consistent with how he portrays himself. *For example, Singapore Mass Rapid Transit (MRT) trains were lauded for improving Singapore's complex transport network, further enhanced by proposals to expand the network with more MRT lines. However MRT breakdowns are becoming increasingly frequent despite declarations that there will be more consistent maintenance and checks on the railway tracks and trains. Train breakdowns have occurred on the north-south line, north-east line and downtown line which has recently just started operating this year.* When there is **inconsistency between appearance and reality**, or between what is said and done, the **colloquialism, "No Action, Talk Only (NATO)" surfaces**. When hypocrisy is evident, resentment is evoked against the hypocrite because he is unable to fulfill what he has promised. As such, when there is an erosion of trust in the particular person or system, **discontentment is evoked** and this leads to **dissenting voices amongst the population**.
- **Giving one a chance to start anew, regardless of background:** One's image that is derived from his **background** should not always affect his future. Sometimes, an unnecessary amount of emphasis is placed on one's background, which defines his image, and poses a hindrance to the number of opportunities available for him. *For example, the Yellow Ribbon Project in Singapore aims to alleviate the inevitably **high levels of prejudice or discrimination against ex-offenders**, to allow them to gain a chance to **start anew**, earn their own income and support their families.* Recently, there is a lot of focus on how a degree is not necessary to **gain an edge in one's career**. *For instance, non-graduate teachers who perform exceedingly well can also gain the chance to obtain the same income as teachers with a degree.* This is another indication of how one's

image defined by his educational background is not as important as what one actually does in his work. Therefore, having **removed the burden of one's background, prejudice is removed** and one can start afresh without being bothered by how he is judged based on his past. In other words, the image that could have hindered him in his career path is now erased as he can craft a new image using **his own effort and merit**. This move to **reduce the importance of one's background in a meritocratic society like Singapore** where **equality of opportunity** is provided for all, spurring citizens who were originally placed at a disadvantage to compete with their more fortunate counterparts, improving **inclusiveness** in society.

Arts

- **Cultural identity:** It has become imperative in many societies to spend resources to develop the arts in order to achieve and inculcate some form of cultural identity. As a result of the exchange and intermingling of many cultures due to the easy accessibility of mass and social media, there has been a reaction by many societies to reevaluate their sense of identity. Nascent societies or societies often resort to the arts as a means to create a sense of identity. **Singapore's rapid rise to a first world nation** in one generation has led to a lot of soul-searching with regards to what it means to be Singaporean. *Traditional art forms such as 'getai', song performances during the Hungry Ghost Festival, to Peranakan bead shoes and kebayas, have seen a resurgence in recent times. Movies such as "15" and "ilo ilo" also show Singapore's struggle to accept people of different backgrounds as a cosmopolitan society.* **A society's cultural identity is often reflected in artists' works**, which help give expression to contemporary views and perceptions about the community at large. Local artists, be they writers, filmmakers, directors, dancers, painters, sculptors or architects, base their artistic efforts on the experience of being a citizen and living in the country, thereby help to create shared perspectives that are distinctively their nation's.
- Arts scene in Singapore is a fledgling one that cannot compare to its counterparts in Paris, London and New York
 - Government has focused on economic growth, causing Arts scene to be neglected
 - Could explain why music artistes such as JJ Lin and Stefanie Sun decided to base in Taiwan given the larger, more promising music market there
 - Local born fashion designer Andrew Gn felt that he could not make a living in Singapore due to lack of receptiveness towards fashion and as such, migrated overseas, where there is perceived to be greater receptiveness and appreciation of art.

- Arts to some extent controlled by the Media Development Authority, which has the authority to censor any form of the Arts deemed inappropriate or potentially harmful to society
- Banning of Tan Pin Pin's film "To Singapore, With Love", a documentary that tells the stories of our island nation's political exiles, who fled during the island's pre-independence years to escape detention without trial
- Arts scene has not been allowed the freedom of expression that those in more liberal societies have.
- Singapore Repertory Theatre has sprung up to prominence in our society. Many aspiring artists from various forms of art have been making use of these avenues to develop their artistic abilities

Films

- **Entertainment value:** successes in the local film industry can seek to **inspire filmmakers to improve their skills** and create more critically acclaimed works, as well as encourage young blood who are keen to work in film to constantly **renew the industry**. *The Singapore film "ilo ilo", directed by Anthony Chen, swept many international prestigious awards. It was the first Singaporean film to win the Camera d'Or award at the 2013 Cannes Film Festival, where it was first released for viewing as part of the Director's Fortnight. It then went on to bag many other accolades at the Golden Horse Awards, such as the Best New Director, Best Original Screenplay, Best Supporting Actress, and even took the state and won the highly coveted Best Film Award, a prize that is only awarded to one film out of all that were nominated.* As the first Singaporean film to land international awards, this has **shone some light on the Singapore film industry**, and brings Singapore **a step closer to being recognised internationally in the film industry**. Most importantly, this success will **serve to motivate local filmmakers and teenagers** that pursuing a future in the film industry **is not an impossible dream**. This message is particularly heartwarming especially in the light of Singapore's emphasis on the biomedical and finance industries. This feat may also help to alleviate the negative stereotypes of the arts, since many may not acknowledge the economic value in pursuing a career

in the arts industry. It is especially the case, since the director Anthony Chen, led a tough life with only \$250 left in his bank account, but manage to persevere against all odds to chase his filmmaking aspirations. This would definitely further **motivate youngsters to pursue their dreams and their passion** even if the task is herculean.

- **Educational value:** films are employed as an **effective medium to convey complex themes and messages to students**. Through its captivating visual and audio effects, movies many very well prove to be an even more operative method to teach students who are **not receptive to the standard didactic approach**. It is a common sight in classrooms for teachers to screen films relevant to the targeted topic of study, to **enable students to get a broad overview of the theme in focus**. Historical documentaries, political commentaries, and investigative series are notable examples of films with educational value which can be aired in classes. *In 2014, the Media Development Authority (MDA) of Singapore gave leeway to institutions of higher learning, such as universities to show restricted films for educational purposes. Yale-NUS College's request to screen Tan Pin Pin's "To Singapore, With Love", a movie about Singapore's political exiles, was allowed by the MDA for the purposes of classroom teaching and discussion. The movie received a "Not Allowed for All Ratings (NAR)" classification from the MDA, a rating which bars public display and distribution. The documentary includes interviews with several political exiles of Singapore, most of them alleged communists with allegiance to the Communist Party of Malaya. Despite the **controversial nature of this documentary**, the fact that the MDA accepted Yale-NUS College's request to screen it for **scholastic reasons goes to underscore the importance and usefulness of films as an educational tool**. Therefore, the significance of films in Singapore as a learning instrument is one that **cannot be undermined** - the features of colourful images, moving music and special effects combined **encapsulate a unique learning experience** that cannot be replicated through any other means.*

- **Reflect social trends in Singapore:** films are able to reflect, with laudable accuracy, social trends prevalent in Singapore, and thus **encourage viewers to think critically about the problems and issues faced by the populace.** Popular local film *“I Not Stupid”* by Jack Neo highlights the nation’s obsession with academic success, an unwavering trend in our meritocratic nation. Throughout the film and its sequel, viewers can observe the problems brought about by an overemphasis on grades and educational pursuits, thus conveying a clear message to the public that there is more to life than academic achievements, especially for young, school-going children. The documentary *“Out in the Cold”* by local producer Wilfred Tan focuses on another aspect of Singapore society which is **largely neglected by the media and the masses - the homeless.** Through videography, **screen time is given to a marginalised group who have been traditionally excluded from the nation’s public discourse.** To many, Singapore is a playground for the rich and powerful worldwide, with the affluent flocking to our shores to protect and maintain their wealth. Amidst this trend, Tan **sheds light on the plight of the homeless,** through the eyes of two homeless men. Through his short film, Tan brings to attention the **predicaments of an often-overlooked group in society,** depicting a Singaporean life from a different perspective. Therefore, films can seek to **deliver important insights on societal trends to the masses,** in a way that is entertaining and communicative. Viewers will thus be **encouraged to think deeply and analytically** about various aspects of the Singapore society, and this may eventually promote changes that can benefit the nation.
- **Importance of films:** the principal significance of film lies in its entertainment value, its capacity to amuse and enthrall viewers and transport them into the story in the movie. Through its ability to fascinate, it is able to **help relieve the weariness of daily life,** and allow moviegoers to relax and unwind after a stressful day, especially in today’s competitive and fast-paced society. In 2013, 10 local films were broadcasted on the big screen in Singapore, bringing the total box-office takings to \$13 million, a 10% increase from 2012. Singapore has a high number of filmgoers per year, with more than 20 million viewers 218 cinema screens such as Golden Village, Shaw Organisation and Cathay Organisation.

These statistics are testament to the increasing popularity of films as an entertainment option, and their efficacy in alleviating the humdrum routines of everyday life. However, films also play roles beyond its mere entertainment function. Movies can aid educational efforts, highlight social and political trends, as well as inspire and encourage digital advancement and career progression.

Music

- **Music to evoke feelings of nationalism:** Music has value in its ability to unite the masses and instill a sense of belonging in them, especially important in an increasingly globalised and cosmopolitan world. Music can be used to **unify a nation or to conjure up nationalistic and patriotic feelings** in people. *For example, national anthems are often a rallying point amongst a country's people, arousing a sense of pride and belonging in citizens every time they are played.* The effect national anthems have on people can be seen in major sporting competitions whereby representative along with supporters of a country often sing their country's anthem proudly whenever it is played at the awards-presentation ceremony. *One of the most recent example was during the Rio Olympics 2016 where Joseph Schooling won Singapore's first gold medal in the olympics and Singapore's national anthem was played on an international sporting arena.* The use of music to **evoke feelings of nationalism** also applies to Singapore, where national day songs are always played when celebrating the country's day of independence on 9th August. *National favourites like "Home" and "Where I belong" are songs that are always played during every celebration to galvanise the crowd, which undeniably shows solidarity and patriotism towards the country.* Living in an increasingly cosmopolitan world, it is **essential that a nation is able to develop a sense of national pride and belonging in its citizens.** As without such feelings of patriotism and loyalty to their country, citizens will not feel the need to contribute and give back to the society that raised them. Therefore, music does have an integral role to play in society as it is able to evoke **a sense of belonging and loyalty** in people living in an increasingly globalised world.

Technology

- **NEWater:** The view that technology can reduce **international conflicts** over resources is applicable in Singapore. *The advent of the NEWater plants in Singapore is emblematic of Singapore's independence in procuring water.* As we are relatively more **self-reliant**, it is unlikely that international relations with Malaysia, who supplies us with water, will be strained as a result of conflicts over water provisions. This is because nations no longer have **a need to compete with each other for limited resources**, as Singapore is now self-sustaining. Therefore, countries no longer have to resort to violence or aggression to secure resources for sustenance.

Gender

- **Male-dominated political scene:** *Even though we have female politicians including Halimah Yacob, Grace Fu, Indranee Rajah and Josephine Teo, the **political scene in Singapore is still largely patriarchal.*** This is evident from the fact that top political appointments are still being held by male leaders, and unlike other developed countries such as **South Korea and Germany**, Singapore has not seen a female politician leading the country.
- **Higher levels of education:** women's rights in Singapore have improved thus far due to higher levels of education and greater awareness among the population of the need for gender equality. As more women in Singapore receive higher education, women's rights have become a greater concern, with the setting up of associations such as the Association of Women for Action and Research (AWARE), which actively campaigns and sights for women's rights through academia and research. With higher education, more women **are filtering through to the higher levels of society**, such as parliament or corporations, where they are able to push for initiatives and policies that promote women's rights. For instance, there are currently 18 elected women in parliament out of 89 elected members in parliament. Some notable ministers include Grace Fu, Minister for Culture, Community and Youth and Halimah Yacob, Speaker of Parliament. **Women's rights have thus far been promulgated** and more measures have been put in place to prevent women from being disadvantaged such as the maternity leave.
- **Greater awareness:** women's rights have improved because women are becoming more empowered and are championing for their own rights. **The general population has also become more cognizant of the rising importance of women's rights.** This is due to the higher levels of education in general, and a **gradual liberalisation** of society due to western cultures, leading to more people placing greater currency in the idea of women's rights. No longer do women have to depend on their female counterparts for rights to be achieved,

but they can depend on society as a whole. *This can be seen in Singapore where opinion pieces in the Straits Times regularly call for greater female empowerment, and these articles are not always written by females.*

- **Glass ceiling:** *only 23% of senior management positions in Singapore are held by women, comparably lower than our ASEAN neighbours. Furthermore, only 7.9% of the directors of Singapore Exchange-listed economies are women, significantly lower than economies such as Malaysia and Hong Kong. Many believe that this is a result of women's choices and not a product of sexism. Women and men are distinctively different and each gender has a specific set of behaviours ascribed to them - men are decisive, strong and make good leaders, while women are comparably less decisive, weaker and are thought to be unable to provide effective leadership. Even women who do not believe in this mindset are stigmatised and deal with misogyny from their male counterparts. Society has the mindset that women are expected to stay at home and take care of children while men should continue to be the breadwinner. Such a **binary and discriminatory view of gender roles and expectations** often mean that there is little structural support for women who choose to do so otherwise. This means that some women who decide to continue with the careers may eventually have to **forsake their aspirations** as there is insufficient support for them due to societal views on gender roles. According to the Ministry of Manpower, 43% of women who are economically inactive cite domestic responsibilities as their reason, while only 8% of males cite domestic responsibilities as their reason for being inactive.*

Sports

- **Sporting culture does not promote violence:** The argument that the emergence of the sports culture reduces aggression is exhibited in Singapore. *Singapore hosted the first Summer Youth Olympics in 2010 and the 28th SEA Games, providing a platform for athletes to participate and compete in various sports.* Although these sports are inherently physical, aggression is ultimately limited because it is **manifested not from malign intent**. The promotion of sportsmanship and inter-cultural knowledge between athletes from different countries would instead **foster closer international ties and reduce the likelihood of belligerence** and conflict between states.
- **Sportsmanship, fair play and teamwork:** Sports imparts values such as sportsmanship, fair play and teamwork. The fundamental to sports is the **visceral experience** we go through while playing it, as opposed to simply reading about these values. Learning to lose graciously and not to be arrogant when winning are important values that we learn directly from sports. There is no better avenue than the sports to **ground these values in young, impressionable teenagers**.
- **Sports unifies the nation:** Sports plays an important role as a common ground for a country **as diverse and pluralistic as Singapore**. There is a certain **unquantifiable quality to sports that draws all of us together**, be it watching or playing sports, sports bonds people of different races, cultures and backgrounds together. Sports in Singapore is a **space that transcends all differences to unite as one** where we can share and celebrate. It helps to bring a nation together, as one Singapore cheering on one team. It is an especially inspirational sight when Singaporeans **from all walks of lives come together** to collectively cheer on our athletes. *In the recent 2016 Rio Olympics, Singaporeans came together to watch Joseph Schooling make history when we won Singapore's first olympic gold medal. Schooling's victory has become a unifying force for our young nation as we rejoice in this historic moment. It*

was not just about winning the medal but also about unifying Singaporeans through a common cause. Not only does it bind our community together, it **enhances our national pride and feelings of patriotism.** This creates a **sense of community and camaraderie** among Singaporeans that we collectively care and aspire towards a common goal of winning. On the sideline, **sports nurtures the ethos of excellence** as it requires its participants to give their very best and put in all that they have. These are important values that have contributed to Singapore's success in the long run.

- **International sporting hub:** Singapore has been taking concrete steps to develop her as an international sporting hub. Having organised major sporting events such as the Youth Olympic Games have contributed to our sporting portfolio. *One of the most notable events would be the Singapore Open, which has grown to an event worth over \$6 million and drew a live attendance of more than 30,000, with top golders such as Roy McIlroy attending the event. Singapore's Sport Council Vision 2030 seeks to **forward the development of sports** and many important steps have been take. In 2015, our National Stadium was completed. Worth over 2.82 billion, it features a 55,000-capacity stadium with a retractable roof, a 6,000-capacity Indoor Aquatic Centre and a 3,000-capacity multi-purpose indoor arena. In 2008, the Singapore Sports Council reported that sporting events generated more than 40 million in local publicity.* There is **great potential for Singapore to shine as an international sporting hub** and for us to **benefit economically via sports.**

- **Sports teams are made up of foreigners:** Our sporting teams do not comprise of locals and are made up of overseas players. This **undermines the purposed of sports in uniting our country.** There have been comments about national teams are made up of overseas players that are here for the money and citizenship, and are not truly Singaporeans. Some feel that the **origin of these players undermines the unity and bonding** that we ought to feel from sports. *For instance, the 2008 Beijing Olympic Team for Table Tennis was made up of several players that were initially from China.* Most believe that these athletes are not really fighting for Singapore as much as they are **fighting for themselves.** In this light, they **do**

not represent our aspirations and goals, but their own. This results in **alienation and distancing between Singaporeans and Singapore national athletes** as Singaporeans feel that there is no point in supporting Team Singapore made up of foreigners.

- **Sports is not seen as a potential career path:** Being an athlete in Singapore is often dismissed as a potential career as many perceives it to be a **meaningless endeavour**. As such, many people choose not to go professional and this **undermines the growth of the sport**. In the long run, such thinking cripples any sporting culture that Singapore seeks to develop. Without youth joining the sports scene, this **impedes the growth of the sporting arena as continuity and vibrancy** is required. Sports as a medium provides **invaluable insight and potential for a country as young as Singapore**. It provides bonding opportunities as a nation and for us to **mature and advance together ahead**. The implementation of sports ensures that a **sporting culture can fester healthily in Singapore**.

Food

- **Food as a unifying force:** Food is significant in Singapore because it **provides a commonality that Singaporeans are able to identify with, promoting unity among the people**. Singaporeans travelling overseas or at home identify themselves with certain types of food. These food form part of the **national identity**, and when Singaporeans eat these food they are reminded of the country. *Examples of these food include the chicken rice and chilli crab. Many of these dishes actually originated from Singapore - enhancing the meaning and significance of these world-renowned dishes.* Food has an important symbolic meaning as well, because some dishes were inspired by the food of different cultures in Singapore. These dishes symbolise the cross-cultural exchange between different races in Singapore, in the past and in the present day. *In the pre-colonial past, Chinese cuisine and Malay cuisine were combined to inspire Peranakan cuisine. During colonial times, Indian food came to influence food in Singapore and the localised “Roti Prata” was created. In recent times, fusion cuisine has become popular in Singapore. For example, the dish “rojak” symbolises* **cross-cultural exchange** *between different groups of society in Singapore.* Hence, food is significant as it forms **part of the social identity and promotes social cohesion** in Singapore. Due to the inter-racial mix of Singaporean food, it becomes **emblematic of our multicultural society**, strengthening the claim that the integration of various races is a success story of the country.
- **Singaporeans adopting a healthier diet:** Food is a sign **of improvement and aspiration**. Singaporeans are switching to a healthier diet. This signifies that the population in Singapore are **increasingly health-conscious**. In this sense, food in Singapore signifies trends in society. *For example, more Singaporeans are buying organic food than before. Ever since independence, it has been observed that Singaporeans are learning to appreciate western fine dining.* This is significant because this trend signifies a strong influence by western liberal cultures. This trend is clear from the promotion of English as the **de facto**

national language, the import of modern technology from the west, as well as the entry of western popular culture. *Restaurants serving French cuisine and other Western fine dining options are popular in Singapore, examples include Swensens, Manhattan Fish Market and fast food choices such as Mcdonalds and KFC.* Recently, Singaporeans are increasingly interested in reviving traditional Chinese, Malay and Indian cuisine, **signifying a willingness to learn from the past and to appreciate cultural roots.** Traditional Chinese coffee-shops are returning to Singapore shopping centres in modern forms, and more people are buying traditional Chinese and Malay cakes and pudding (e.g. Ya Kun Kaya Toast, Toast Box, Bengawan Solo). On top of serving as a means to **integrate a diversity of cultures, food also reflects the people's appreciation of our histories and new cultures,** elevating the cultural knowledge of our citizens, which serve as important knowledge for the globalised time and age.

- **Food as a driver of economic growth:** In the competitive tourist market, food can **help promote tourism and boost economic growth.** Singapore is well known for its cuisine, attracting tourists from around the world. Singapore's tourism campaigns never fail to highlight the local cuisine, and it can be observed that foreigners are very much aware of the quality of Singaporean food. Food has indeed become one of the reasons why tourists choose to come to Singapore, bringing with them **tourism revenue.** As a result of its unique cuisine, Singapore receives global attention. In fact, foreigners visit Singapore to learn food preparation from Singaporeans chefs and hawkers. *For example, Gordon Ramsay came from the UK to learn how to prepare chilli crab, chicken rice and laksa from local hawkers and publicised his contest with hawkers in Singapore.* *Singaporean food undoubtedly gain **prominence in the global arena** following Ramsay's visit and contest.* Therefore, the benefits of food are not simply immaterial. Food is a **potential source of revenue,** especially for an economy whose focus is primary on the tertiary industries which specialises in the provision of high-end services. Therefore, it is a **vital source of economic development** which should not be overlooked.

- **Racial segregation:** In Singapore's **multiracial and multicultural society**, food can be a **socially divisive force**. Singaporeans are of different religions and some food cannot be eaten by those of certain religions. *For example, Hindus cannot take beef and Muslims cannot take pork and non-halal food. This brings about **racial segregation** because some restaurants cannot be frequented by some people. In fact, the dominant Chinese population of Singapore probably rarely encounter friends from the Muslim faith during meals and restaurant visits, because Chinese restaurants usually do not serve halal food.* This means that the two races **have less opportunity to interact and understand each other**. With **fewer chances for interaction, alienation and segregation may result**. Even during occasions when different races do mix in Singapore, some people may be **insensitive to the needs of other races**, and end up offending their friends at the dinner table. *For example, Muslims cannot be served non-halal food, and during Ramadan month, Muslims fast. Chinese and Indians who are unaware of these rules may end up upsetting their Muslim friends.* Food is significant as it **accentuates cultural differences between the different races in Singapore**. Due to strict religious rules, **insensitivity and intolerance toward other races might be potential causes of racial tension**, which **threaten/undermine the social fabric of society**.

Environment

- **Individual efforts can contribute to environmental conservation:** Conscious adoption of environmentally-friendly practices by individuals can be significant enough to make a difference in alleviating environmental problems. If every individual commits to reducing their ecological footprint, this will **culminate in an overall significant reduction** in the environmental impact. *For example, the NEA in Singapore recognises how small individual actions can lead to tremendous change in society, and thus called for individuals to adopt environmentally friendly behaviour through campaigns such as the “Reduce, Reuse, Recycle” and the “Bring Your Own Bag Day” initiatives. These campaigns eventually led to an increase in Singapore’s recycling rate by 60% in 2012 according to Singapore Department of Statistics (DOS).* This substantially reduced the country's carbon emission, as it resulted in less waste being sent to the incinerator, showing how **harnessing efforts by individuals** can have a significant effect on the environment. Therefore, it is not true that an individual’s limited capabilities will fail to make a difference in the light of the **huge and complex environmental problems** we are facing today, as when harnessed as a collective whole, **individual efforts can be significant enough** to effect a positive change.

Race and Religion - Government Efforts

- **Education and language:** Other than administrative measures to ensure racial equality, such as the Housing Development Board racial quotas and the group representative constituencies, language policy has been key in the maintenance of **racial and religious cohesion** in Singapore. Singapore’s meritocratic approach is very important - it gives everybody an **equal chance “regardless of race, language or religion”**. *By declaring English as the first language, all schools have been forced to change their subject medium to English, with the exception of Mother Tongue. English language education helps to **develop of common identity** and improves communication between the different races.*

This is **imperative to allow the basic communication between different races**, and recently, **nationalities**, which is the most fundamental step for the coexistence of different races. The judicious government policies and legislation against racism have again provided the means and platforms for the **smooth integration and cohabitation of different races in proximity**. By setting the stage for an inter-racial mix in various communities, as well as a strong emphasis on cultural literacy in schools, inter-racial bonds can be forged relatively more naturally and ideally, pre-conceived stereotypes or prejudice can be eradicated through time. Singapore must be lauded as a real success story in comparison with its First World counterparts, where countries such as the US and those in the EU are still plagued by **rampant racism and xenophobia**. Evidently, Singapore's success is testament to the fact that racial harmony can indeed be attained with sufficient government regulation and policing, as well as adequate education and communal living should be inculcated from early childhood.

- **Public housing:** Other than solving the housing shortage, homeownership gave people **a stake in their country and reduced the sense of transience characteristic** of the migrant population. It also helps to preserve traditional Asian family values where young couples are encouraged to buy/rent apartments near their parents. Public housing serves as an **effective mechanism for social engineering**, where it helped to put the different races in closer proximity (*ceilings on ethnic ratios*). When people live in racial segregation, they become insular and **parochial**, and this **ignorance breeds prejudice and distrust**. The close proximity and forced interaction between the different races **helped to ease preconceived opinions and mistrust**, and hence increased **understanding and tolerance**. The different races living side by side have to be mindful of each other religious practices and personal space.
- **Group Representative Constituency:** The representation of **minority races in positions of authority** was deliberately done to ensure that, in the face of the overwhelmingly Chinese population, the minority races, particularly the Malays

were not discriminated against. *The first three heads of state Yusof Ishak, Benjamin Sheares and CV Devan Nair were all non-chinese. The government has also taken great care to ensure a multi-racial cabinet, foreign service, armed forces, etc.* The multicultural makeup of Singapore's Cabinet and Public Service **symbolises and represents its cosmopolitan nature.** Allowing Singaporeans of different races to interact in all segments of society helped to **forge understanding and acceptance amongst all groups.**

- **5 Self Help Associations:** *The 5 self-help associations in Singapore includes the Chinese Development Assistance Council (CDAC), Mendaki, Singapore Indian Development Association (SINDA), Eurasian Association (EA), Association of Malay Professionals (AMP).* These groups enable the more successful members to help others of the same ethnic group to improve. They are effective because of the **easier communication, greater understanding of members specific needs, and a better ability to handle sensitive internal racial issues** between members of the same ethnic group. They are important for the nation as progress achieved by every community **will strengthen the cohesion of Singapore** and enhance competitiveness and thus stimulate the economy, generating benefits for everyone. Though it may be perceived that these 5 groups may segregate and divide Singaporeans into different ethnic groups and thus impede efforts at nation building, they actually serve as **vehicles for the various ethnic groups to mesh and work together** (such as jointly organising a myriad of recreational and educational programmes and courses). Fundamentally, as long as the **leadership and ideals of the self-help groups are aligned with the national ideals of racial and religious harmony**, their existence can only be a **boon to the harmony of our multicultural society.**

Race and Religion - Importance to Singaporeans

- **Religion gives one's life purpose:** Without religion, **people's lives would be totally lacking of meaning and purpose.** This is reflective of Singapore's context as Singapore is defined by its **multi-religious character.** All 4 major world religions are represented in Singapore. Mosques are overflowing on Fridays, churches on sundays and temples on religions occasions like the Thaipusam or Vesak Day. In the 2010 Census undertaken by the government, only 17% claim to be without any religion. The Inter-Religious organisation is a central institution to the peace and stability experienced in Singapore. Ten religions are represented in the IRO, namely Hinduism, Judaism, Zoroastrianism, Buddhism, Taoism, Jainism, Christianity, Islam, Sikhism, and the Baha'i Faith and they play a central role on many civic roles in Singapore. While this is by no means tell us about the centrality of God in the lives of people. It is at the very least signals that **Singaporeans' do see the importance and relevance of religion to their lives.**

- We need to be **more open-minded and accept that there are other approaches to find meaning in life** apart from religion or God. In a **diverse society like Singapore**, there is a need to draw people together rather than be divided into religious mental-enclaves. In this common space, citizens must practise as much **secularism**, and be as inclusive as possible. This common space was threatened on quite a few occasions *such as the controversy over the right to wear the tudung to school issue as well as the 'AWARE' episode where religiously-motivated individuals try to gain control of a secular organisation.* In both situations, the government came on very strongly to protect the schools and NGO respectively from being divided along racial or religious lines. As a **cosmopolitan society whose economic well-being** is based on ensuring an **open and welcoming society**, it is imperative that Singaporeans are willing to accept secular and possibly materialistic definition of happiness and meaning. In other words, religious differences must be cast aside in pursuit of common

values that everyone can identify with for a diverse society to gain solidarity and national unity.

- However, because of the plural nature of Singapore society and an increasingly willingness to voice opinions, a number of value and belief systems threaten the generally conservative values that bind Singaporeans together. *The most current search for meaning is the desire to seek acceptance by marginalised groups such as the LGBT community. Their values and beliefs have come into conflict with the more conservative members of our society.* Therefore, without a **firm subscription to a religious doctrine**, a society that is more open might not be united in different controversial issues. Singapore still needs to learn to produce a meaningful life for all groups by **endorsing unorthodox values or beliefs and increase tolerance and understanding.**

Race and Religious Discrimination

- **Minority races are placed at a disadvantage:** The constitution of the Republic of Singapore states that “the Government shall exercise its functions in such manner as to recognise the special position of the Malays, who are the indigenous people of Singapore, and accordingly it shall be the responsibility of the Government to protect, safeguard, support, foster and promote their political, educational, religious, economic, social and cultural interests and the Malay language”. *In addition, national examination fees are waived for madrasah students in the 2015 National Budget and the Islamic Religious Council of Singapore (MUIS) has increased funding to full-time madrasahs and financial assistance to needy students. In contrast, other religious schools do not receive funding directly from the government, but via private charity. Moreover, Malay students with a monthly household per capita income below \$1,500 receive up to 100% subsidy for tertiary education under the Mendaki Tertiary Tuition Fee Subsidy (TTFS). Amy Cheong’s dismissal from the National Trades Union Congress (NTUC) as a result of her racist rant on Facebook showcases*

Singapore's **strict stance on racism in a multi-religious society**. Clearly, racism is not tolerated as the scars from historical events, such as the Maria Hertogh riots in 1950, are testament to the **importance of religious sensitivity and mutual respect to maintain the social fabric and cohesion** in the country.

- **Racial discrimination in the education system:** The late former Prime Minister, Mr Lee Kuan Yew's advocacy of eugenics and social engineering has sparked controversy and public outrage. *He used the notion that intelligence is inherited to explain the greater proportion of Chinese graduating from tertiary education, based on the assumption that most marriages are not inter-racial. In the same book, Hard Truths, Mr Lee stated that "he told the Malay leaders that they will never close the academic gap within the Indians and the Chinese. The Malays are improving but they are not closing the gap. That's a fact of life."* Such a **politically incorrect statement, coupled with education policies that seem to favour the Chinese**, such as the preservation of Chinese-dominated schools in the Special Assistance Plan (SAP) might possibly **provide the grounds for racial discontent** towards the inherently discriminatory attitude the education system in Singapore proposes.

Tourism (exploitation)

- **Tourists are being exploited:** the lack of familiarity with the environment provides **prime opportunities for unscrupulous vendors to take advantage of foreigners**. Touts target tourists in various places such as Boat Quay, Newton Hawker Centre, Sim Lim Square and Lucky Plaza, and even some tour agencies do not give tourists a fair deal and **exploit the ignorance of tourists** to make a quick buck. Singapore also **panders to the needs of tourists** by not giving them an accurate experience of Singapore. Tourists are only given a **sterile view of Singapore's civic district, Chinatown, Geylang Serai and Little India** and not the real lives of people they should want to experience. *There is exploitation of tourist ignorance to artificially sustain trades like trishaw-pulling to give 'cultural experience'. There is also exploitation of gambling culture of well-heeled East*

Asians to set up Integrated Resorts. Tourists are exploited as they lack the locals' experience in navigating potential pitfalls on the shopping and eating scene. Therefore, unsuspecting tourists who fail to do prior research often fall prey to unscrupulous vendors who are profit-maximising in their businesses and aim to make a quick and easy buck off them.

- **Avenues to find out about the country:** tourism is a crucial industry to Singapore and it would not be in Singapore's interest to exploit tourists and leave them with a bad impression. There are constant crackdowns by law enforcement agencies on touts in places of interests. There are channels of feedback through personnel involved in the industry. *The rise of travel review websites dedicated to tourist comments and feedback such as Tripadvisor, Expedia and various blogs have also forced people to be more careful and scrupulous in service. Most service industries in Singapore are **highly regulated and accredited**, such as the transport network and main shopping belts.*
- **Tourism as a driver of economic growth:** tourism is a catalyst for economic growth as it is a key source of revenue, heavily geared towards a '**hub status**' **for almost everything**. *The reputation of Changi Airport and the iconic Singapore Airlines attracts all sorts of travellers. Tourism accounts for more than 8% of Singapore's GDP.* Singapore provides business travellers an effective location to facilitate business meetings. Singapore is focused on the MICE (meetings, incentives, conventions and exhibitions) concept of tourism through the building of infrastructure of the Marina Bay Sands, the Singapore Expo and the Suntec City Convention Centre. *Large scale events such as sell-out concerts, travelling exhibitions, meetings of the World Trade Organisation, APEC and the World Economic Forum and held here.* This is evident that tourism in Singapore is about **engendering a positive reputation** so that it can be a **sustainable source of revenue to the country in the long run**.
- **Tourism benefits locals:** locals also benefit from the construction of tourism infrastructure and the income generated from the tourism industry. There are effective win-win strategies for both locals and tourists. Locals benefit from and

enjoy the **infrastructure built to cater to tourists** such as shows at the Integrated Resorts, the theme parks and the general improvement in customer service and experience in the shopping areas and restaurants. There are good employment prospects for locals in the F&B industry, with training schools like Singapore Hotel and Tourism Education Centre (SHATEC) and the Institute of Technical Engineering (ITE) providing training to individuals to pursue related careers.

Immigration

- **Singapore is too competitive: Foreignness helps us in “escaping” the life we have back home**, leaving behind our responsibilities and expectations of us. *Many Singaporeans have the opportunity to spend lengthy periods of time overseas either for work, exchange programmes or when they pursue a degree and a large number of these people who have experienced life overseas year for the experience again when they finally have to return to Singapore.* With **increasing mobility and Singapore being a highly globalised city state**, an increasing number of Singaporeans are working and studying abroad. As of 2014, 212,000 Singaporeans were living overseas, compared with 157,800 in 2004, increasing by more than a third over the past decade. A major contributing factor is that western countries are particularly appealing as they are often viewed as places where **an individual can escape the rat race of Singapore**. Therefore, many Singaporeans **might give up their citizenship for a slow-paced, less competitive environment that a foreign country can offer**, which defies local expectations that they might not be willing to subscribe to.

- **Challenging to assimilate to the culture of a foreign country:** however, some Singaporeans truly appreciate their country of origin only after immigration. Being a foreigner thus **strengthens their sense of belonging to their home country**. *The popularity of 'Singapore Day' in various major cities around the world where Singaporeans often attend to have a taste of home-cooked food and hear the Singaporean accent could suggest that while some degree of escape is desirable, memories and emotions take a lot more effort to break free.* There are Singaporeans who choose to return to Singapore despite having tried migrating to another country. Sometimes, it is even more difficult to **assimilate to the culture of a foreign country** where one is **not exposed to their norms and practices from a young age**. On the contrary, living in a **foreign space might reinforce one's appreciation of his home** that might eventually drive him to return despite the flaws or push factors of his home country.
- **Contributing back to society: Singaporeans can still contribute to the country when they return.** In Singapore, with cheaper airfares and the advent of technology, the means to keep contact with loved ones is easily accessible and affordable. One can simply use Skype or Google Hangout to make a video call via the Internet back home. *In addition, government policies such as mandatory National Service ensure that all male citizens and permanent residents who grew up in Singapore has to contribute by serving 2 years of conscription.* Therefore any male citizen who wishes to immigrate, albeit temporarily or permanently, would not feel the guilt of 'betrayal' since they have already **served their obligation**. Hence it would be superficial to claim that one would be guilty for leaving the country of origin since there are many ways where he can stay connected and repay the society that has brought him to success. Furthermore, in most cases, Singaporeans only immigrate temporarily for reasons **such as higher education and business deals**, and would eventually return to Singapore and contribute to the workforce.

- **More responsible and aware global citizen:** Immigration and experiencing other cultures can make a person more tolerant/aware/become a global citizen. Immigration can **promote cultural literacy** as one becomes more **sensitive of the differences in foreign cultures** such as the acceptance of differences is a crucial mindset in promoting global harmony.
- **Immigration as a pursuit for personal gains:** Formation of a global identity is not so prevalent since most immigrants leave or enter the country for personal reasons. The former results in brain drain and the latter results in an elite, exclusive class or expatriates who enjoy high living standards. In a way, Singapore is a victim of its own success. Having such an open and cosmopolitan society with such an educated workforce, **our sense of rootedness becomes more tenuous**. With such a wide worldview, Singaporeans are more than able to seek a life or employment in other countries. Therefore, the rationale behind immigration is rarely for nationalistic or communal sentiments, but for **the pursuit of individual dreams (pragmatism)**. Hardly, anyone migrates solely for the sake of understanding the worlds since there are more repressing personal goals and desires to be fulfilled.

Xenophobia

- **Poor foreigners who are struggling to make ends meet:** Foreigners are allowed entry into developed countries today because they offer cheap labour in lower-tier jobs that the locals do not wish to be employed in most of the time, these foreigners have to send their hard-earned income back as remittances and their remaining income is barely sufficient to sustain a living. This is evident from many cases where foreign workers cannot afford proper housing and have to live in cramped and inhumane conditions in accommodation built for them. *With the large number of foreign Work Permit and S-Pass holders in Singapore, foreigners frequently face and need to deal with the problem of discrimination when they are overseas. Not all foreigners are expatriates or PMET (Professional, Managerial, Executives, Technicians). In fact, only 12% of Singapore's non-resident population are higher-skilled foreigners. This was clearly seen in the aftermath of the Population White Paper.* The strong public reaction to the fear of being outnumbered by foreigners in the near future led many Singaporeans to take on a nationalistic or even xenophobic tone to foreigners. Therefore, it can be seen that foreigners who immigrate in search of a better job and financial stability as compared to their countries of origin **might face socio-economic discrimination in terms of lower wages and rejection by the local populace.**
- **Tightened immigration control:** Singapore has **tightened immigration control**, which serves as a signal that not all foreign workers are welcome in a country that supposedly accepts people of various races and nationalities. In response to frustrated Singaporeans who feel that the government favours foreigners over locals, the government made various adjustments to its policies, limiting the number of foreigners in various areas. *For example, the proportion of places catered to foreign students in local universities would decrease, students of foreign nationalities are not allowed to work in Singapore during their vacation unless they are granted Work Pass exemption, and the number of PR visas has*

decreased. In a move to **placate the unhappy Singaporeans**, it is common to find practices that place foreigners at a disadvantage, which reinforces the notion that foreigners will not necessarily find their utopic country after immigration.

- **Unhappiness towards migrants:** As Singaporeans feel more threatened by increasing competition, such unhappiness **has often been targeted at migrants**. While race relations between the main ethnic groups in Singapore has stabilised, *the threat of job competition from foreign manpower, perceptions of overcrowding and its attendant effects on our transport infrastructure, and a perceived lack of social graces have caused an* **increasing sense of xenophobia and widespread frustration** *that may be insensitive. Online vitriol is on the rise, especially with negative comments about migrants to Singapore.* This could **potentially undermine Singapore's reputation as a stable, welcoming and cosmopolitan society** which is central to her continuing relevance to the world at large.

Singapore Airlines

- **Willingness to innovate:** Despite the competitiveness of the aviation industry, SIA has managed to stay at the front of the pack for many years. In 2016, Singapore Airlines was ranked the 3rd best airline in the world. To stay ahead of the competition, SIA has always been willing to innovate and try out new ideas. *SIA has a Production Innovation Department, which specialises in formulating new products to be rolled out to consumers and commit 30% of its annual spending to this. In 1970s, SIA was the first to offer meal choices, free drinks and free headsets in Economy Class. In 2004, SIA was again the first to offer a non-stop flight between Singapore and New York. To ensure its food taste as good when in the sky, SIA also invested \$700,000 in a facility to enable chefs to taste food under pressurised flight conditions.* SIA's ability to think out of the box has enabled it to **differentiate itself in a competitive industry**. This has given it a **front- runner advantage in seizing market share**. Furthermore, it creates a perception of SIA as the industry's leading player and boosts its image

to consumers and corporate entities. The publicity generated in the media by these groundbreaking innovations serves the additional function advertising SIA as the leading carrier choice.

- **Continued service excellence through a strict selection process and investment in training:** A defining feature of the SIA is its commitment to provide the best service, which has allowed it to differentiate itself as a premium luxury carrier. To ensure the quality of its service, SIA implements a **rigorous screening process** for those applying to be part of the cabin crew. *The selection process consists of a group interview, a one-on-one interview, a psychometric test, a uniform test, a water confidence test, and a management round of interview. Only 3-4% of the applicants are eventually hired.* In addition to the selection process, SIA **invests heavily in the training of its staff**. A newly recruited employee would have to go through a four-month training course, that is one of the longest in the industry. *The Transforming Customer Service helps to teach employees how to manage **the individual needs of passengers and enhances their ability to deliver passengers' satisfaction.*** Training is not limited to new employees and existing employees are regularly sent for further training over their course of career at the SIA. *each of the 14,500 employees undergoes 110 hours of retraining every year at a cost of \$70 million.* **These measures have enabled SIA to continually maintain a high level of service excellence,** translating to better customer experience. This enables the company to retain its existing customers, while attracting new ones.

- **Supportive and collaborative environment:** SIA places emphasis on the workplace environment of its staff. To **promote teamwork and a sense of esprit de corps**, cabin crews are divided into smaller units of 13 people and arranged to fly together as far as possible. By allowing members to work with **familiar faces**, this allows them to know each other better and over time build up an understanding. Since SIA has around 6,600 crew members in total, this initiative enables **effective man-management and provides a comfortable environment** for the employee to work in. With better communication and high employee satisfaction, cabin crews are able to focus on their jobs and deliver better services to the passengers. In addition, this initiative helps to ease new employees into the job, which can be difficult due to the irregular nature of the job, as a result, they are more likely to stay on after their training, saving training costs on new employees.
- **Diversification into the budget airlines sector:** With the rise of the budget airlines sector in recent years, SIA has managed to **participate in this new market without diluting its brand** through the incorporation of subsidiary companies. *SIA introduced Tiger Airways in 2007 and Scoot in 2012 to compete with other low-cost carriers in the region. SIA is currently a substantial shareholder in Tiger Airways and the sole shareholder of Scoot.* By incorporating subsidiary companies, SIA is able to **separate the risk of entering a new market in budget airlines from its core business**. It also prevents the **dilution of the SIA brand**, one of luxury, comfort and first-class service. On the other hand, it enables the SIA to enter the low-cost carrier sector. If the ventures are successful, the profits will flow back into SIA through its receipt of dividends as a shareholder. As a result, SIA stands to benefit from the increasing market share of budget airlines. At the same time, it is able to move SIA **towards the higher end of the market** to further differentiate itself from other premium carriers. Therefore, SIA has not been as adversely affected by the low-cost flying sector as much as other traditional airlines, some of which have become insolvent in recent years.

- **Comprehensive business model:** A comprehensive business model has allowed SIA to maintain its attractiveness and reduce its dependency on air travel. SIA has developed a business model that covers other related aspects of air travel such as hotels, leading to increased revenues and a **holistic customer experience**. *The KrisFlyer programme for frequent flyers has a range of benefits such as discounts with hotels, restaurants and retailers. To be in line with its glamorous image, SIA selects its partners carefully from the high-end sector, such as Ritz- Carlton.* This contributes to the attractiveness of the KrisFlyer programme, which in turn encourages customers to fly with SIA regularly. Furthermore, the KrisFlyer programme has enabled SIA to increase its sources of revenues because it has negotiated commissions with its partners. thus , SIA is able to benefit financially from spending by its frequent flyers. With income streams from other sectors such as hotel and retail, SIA is **less prone to fluctuations in the aviation industry**. Therefore, SIA has been able to differentiate itself with its high-end KrisFlyer programme and earn additional revenue at the same time.

Humility

- **Humility to admit to one's mistakes:** Despite increasing individualism and competition, humility is still a virtue that we hold dear today, especially in societies **entrenches by traditional, conservative values**. Various traditions and cultures continue to **inculcate a sense of propriety and humility during interpersonal interactions**. Traditional societies still hold religious values with high regard. Once a religious leader leads a life of excess, the media and many individuals will be quick to criticise. *The cases and public reactions against religious leaders such as Kong Hee and Reverend Ming Yi in Singapore show how immodesty, where excessive pride deters one from admitting to his mistakes, is not tolerated.* Hence, despite increasing individualism and competition, **humility is a virtue** that we hold dear today, especially in societies **entrenches by traditional, conservative values**.

- **Tolerance and acceptance of different groups in society:** Humility promotes **sensitivity and tolerance of differing views**. When one becomes more open-minded, he is able to accept different perspectives and conflicts that arise because of **insensitivity and an unwillingness to accept contrasting opinions**, especially in political and religious extremism, will be greatly reduced. Therefore, humility is crucial in our multiracial and multireligious society.

Value of Buildings

- **Social, political and religious significance in bringing different people together:** Buildings are **platforms for uniting the people** regardless of their similarities or differences, **strengthening our social identity as well as forging ineradicable ties with others**. *In Singapore, HDB flats are copious within most neighbourhoods, with more than 80% of Singaporeans living in these flats.* To residents, these buildings could just be convenient accommodation for one's own family but from the standpoint of the government, **building are tools for nation building**. In the hope that Singaporeans **embrace the racial differences among one another and interact with fellow residents from other races**, *ethnic quotas are established for each HDB estate. Facilities such as fitness corners, playgrounds and community centres are constructed for neighbours to bond through spending hours of leisure together. Beyond places of residence, **educational institutions** are significant in convening students from various walks of life together. Schools enable students to meet people from varying economic and social backgrounds, even more so with the establishment of several international exchange programmes.* In this context, buildings **facilitate interaction with people from other parts of the world**, helping Singaporeans to broaden their perspectives, as well as to **create strong ties with their global peers**.

- **Buildings can bring people of similar interests together:** There are buildings in place for the different faiths practiced in Singapore, with churches, temples and mosques found in several districts. *Places such as the National Stadium, sports hubs and complexes **unite the sports enthusiasts**, while those passionate in the arts may congregate in theatres or museums.* Having such platforms in place for like-minded people to gather would promote the exchange of new ideas and talents, and therefore strengthening our ability in these domains. However, the Star Performing Arts Centre (PAC) at the Star Vista mall happens to be a business arm of the New Creation Church in Singapore, which holds its services at that venue weekly. It becomes apparent that different values accorded to the same venue by **people with different beliefs** may cause some friction, *such as when the gay singer Adam Lambert travelled to Singapore to perform at The Star PAC, sparking discussions online with regards to the suitability of the concert venue.*
- **Economic significance (tourism):** In this era of rapid globalisation, it is important to **innovate and utilise modern infrastructure** in the quest for our nation to make formidable economic progress. Despite the lack of natural landscapes, mountains to hike or different seasons to enjoy, Singapore has still been thriving as a tourist destination, with tourism making up 10% of Singapore's GDP. *The **construction of impressive infrastructure** such as the Universal Studios theme park, museum and casino at the RWS, or Gardens by the Bay, we have **attracted tourists from all over the world to this seemingly small island.*** Singaporeans might lament that they live in a mundane city that with a lack of fascinating attractions, for these structures that they probably have seen or passed by umpteen times are of little or no value to them. There might also be some degree of disgruntlement upon considering that the construction of these flamboyant but impractical structures have been funded by the taxes they have paid. Nonetheless, these destinations still appear beguiling to tourists, who would admire them for their **novelty and aesthetic value**, especially on

transitory visits like vacations. **Sensationalization by media** such as tourism agency advertisements or reviews from lifestyle bloggers may be a cause for the high value accorded to certain attractions. *The presence of most essential facilities such as convenient stores or food courts within walking distance, and the maintenance of the general cleanliness of buildings throughout the country, are important factors that have made Singapore a desirable place for holiday and migration.* Facilities that are readily available and accessible buildings such as supermarkets, sports complexes and malls may sometimes be taken for granted by Singaporeans, who have always enjoyed this convenience at their fingertips. Migrants might better appreciate this **expediency of resources as well as security in the various buildings aforementioned**, which might be the very factors that have drawn them to this country.

- **Economic significance (investors):** Even with spatial constraints, *there is still presence of ample infrastructure for commerce and trade, with places such as the Jurong industrial Park, Biopolis and the myriad of commercial buildings in the CBD.* The erection of such formidable infrastructure in place has indeed **successfully attracted many global investors and MNCs to Singapore**, since they assign great value to the presence of abundant facilities and well-established transport network before proceeding to pump in capital. Such investment has undoubtedly been of great value to the country's economic growth.

- **Status symbols on an individual level:** Being people who view status highly, Singaporeans might view one's place of residence or workplace as an indication of one's social standing. The different types of properties in Singapore such as public housing (HDBs) and private housing (condominium and landed properties) vary largely in prices, hence leading to some to view property as a significant symbol of social status. **In a pragmatic society aghast with materialism**, it comes as no surprise that the **monetary value of possessions** such as property is associated with status, and an "upgrade" from public housing to private housing serves as an indication of one's movement up the social ladder. Of course, such a view may not be predominant among all citizens, for not all may accord such high value to their place of residence as a **representation of status**.
- **Social and cultural significance on an international level:** Places of commerce and leisure may be regarded as **status symbols on international level**. Beyond the individual, the type of buildings can portray the success in economic advancement and cultural development of a country. The skyscraper filled skyline at MBS is undoubtedly an indication of the vast improvements our nation has made over the past 50 years, whilst new buildings are constantly springing up to show her continuous strive for progress. Only a country with **substantial infrastructure** would have the ability to **host large-scale events such as the Youth Olympic Games, SEA Games, or ASEAN Summits**, for there must be accommodation catered for the global delegates or athletes, as well as impressive venues for the undertaking of the events. Having a significant number of places such as the Art Science Museum or Esplanade Theatres also makes Singapore seem to be a place that is **rich in the arts and culture domain**, hence drawing renowned artists from all over the world to our country as well. In creating a reputation for our country globally, the buildings of this city have played a significant role. By serving as a signs of improvement and aspiration, as well as colossal venues for various occasions, they are bound to have left remarkable

impressions on the tourists, participants and international audience of the large-scale events, which have certainly helped to bump our **international standing**.

Meaning in Life

- A meaningful life must **consist of both being engaged in society and leading moral lives**. In Singapore, we have a **tough stance against crimes**. **Social stability and well-being** are so important to Singapore that serious crimes that harm large sections of our society such as drug trafficking are punishable with the death sentence. Furthermore, the Internal Security Act also allows for detention without trial for people suspected of encouraging or seeking social instability through terrorism or gang activity. In this sense, the Singapore government **takes a very active hand** in ensuring that people are allowed to find meaning in their lives in a pro-social, ethical fashion. Singaporeans are also encouraged to live meaningful lives by being engaged in helping the less fortunate. *The Law Society, for instance, have set up a pro bono department to encourage lawyers to invest their time and resources to avail free legal services for those in society that cannot afford it.* Perhaps, with the majority of Singaporeans having attained a more comfortable standard of living, and who are not seeking a clearer Singapore identity, it has become important to build social cohesion by caring for the less fortunate.

Fast paced life

- **Unavoidable for a better future:** the fast pace of life in Singapore is unavoidable, necessary and has paved the way for Singaporeans to achieve a higher standard of living. As an **economically motivated society**, being competitive and being plugged into the global trade and financial system is part of Singapore's DNA. **Competing on a global level requires a frenetic pace of life** and that has helped us maintain **our position as a global financial centre**. Singapore also has to remain relevant and attractive to migrants and economic success is necessary to keep attracting people to Singapore to help mitigate our falling birth rates and a lack of trained manpower. *Since Singapore severely lacks any resources that makes us self-sufficient, we have to rely on our **niche ability to value-add products and services**. Fields such as finance, knowledge-based industries and high end manufacturing require a constant upgrading of skills for their workforce.* Competition is also necessary as there is a global war for talent. Singapore benefits from the inflow of talent from around the world. An **accelerated pace of life** provides the **requisite competitive environment** for sustainable economic growth, which is the **main engine for perpetuating economic attractiveness for foreign investment**. Therefore, a fast tempo in Singaporean life is necessary.

- **To remain competitive in the global arena:** the fast pace of living and the competitive environment has helped Singapore benefit from a reputation of **excellence, stability and dependability**, which has helped Singapore maintain its relevance and position in the global arena. Singapore's world class education system and its **clear focus on providing her people with competitive and relevant skills** has helped keep her population globally relevant. People have access to high quality jobs and a high standard of living in terms of infrastructure, housing and healthcare. *Having been **trained to constantly seek perfection**, Singapore's workforce and the government has constructed infrastructure such as Changi Airport, the Port of Singapore Authority (PSA), Marina Bay Financial*

*Centre, and recreation venues such as Resort World Sentosa and Marina Bay Sands. A **swift momentum in life propels a shared attitude in the population for self-driven success and independence.** It engenders a **positive and rigorous work ethic** in the local workforce, which attracts global investors and think tanks. An increasing concentration in the local deployment of these international powerhouses further enhance Singapore's reputation as an alpha city comparable to the likes of New York City and Tokyo.*

- **People want a less fast paced life:** while the fast pace of life is crucial and largely beneficial to Singapore, **certain segments of Singapore's population** feel that the pace of life is increasingly **untenable and harmful**, and have raised a desire for a more manageable pace of life and desire of work-life balance. There is an increasing segment of Singapore's population who are asking for a re-think of Singapore's **approach for pure economic growth at the expense of other aspects of life.** *While Singapore has a high standard of living relative to many neighbouring countries, more locals are complaining about the flaws of living in Singapore. There has been increasing discussions about the increasing number of Singaporeans who have or are planning to migrate to other countries with a slower pace of life for themselves and a less stressful school environment for their children. In order to be **competitive and maintain a comfortable level of income,** many families are dual-income in nature.* While the outstanding work ethic of Singaporeans benefits the economy, there is an undeniably mounting cost to family life. More childless couples are putting off the idea of having children despite constant pleas by the authorities to do so. Such couples are worried that children in Singapore may not have much of a childhood **due to the competitive school environment.** Families with children have to resort to hiring foreign domestic workers, placing their children in childcare centres for the entire workday, or enlisting the help of elderly grandparents. As a result, there is **growing unhappiness and frustration about having insufficient time** to spend time with loved ones. A fast pace of life **marginalises family time** in favour of **inevitable economic pursuits, and propagates and increase in the level of competition across society** for limited resources, which may come across as undesirable to the younger generations. Therefore, a fast pace of life

may be **inadmissible for the social costs it brings to the emotional well-being of a population which prizes a degree of individuality and freedom** in addition to economic sustainability.

- **Inequality within the population:** the frenetic pace of life and the many changes that accompany such a pace while beneficial to Singapore as a whole, have **left sizeable segments of the population behind in terms of economic and social developments**, and caused a degree of suffering and disgruntlement. While younger Singaporeans have been endowed with the necessary IT skills and training needed, there are a group of Singaporeans who are **vulnerable to being retrenched**. *Once, retrenched, those individuals who are in their 50s, and belong to the Professional, Managerial, Executive and Technical (PMET) sectors of industry find it almost impossible to be re-hired. The use of English language and the focus on technology in Singapore today has also left much of the* **elderly population alienated from the rest of society**. While Singapore would not be where it is today without the pioneer generation, elderly folk who mostly communicate in dialects and did not receive the benefits of Singapore's post-independence education system, have been largely marginalised in society. This is **further exacerbated by Singapore not being a welfare state**, and thus minimises the disbursement of pensions to elderly dependents. As a result, it is not uncommon to see these elderly folk performing **more menial tasks** such as clearing tables at dining places or scrounging for discarded goods.

- **More efforts for work-life balance:** there is an increasing **awareness and drive to manage the pace of life** in Singapore to make it agreeable and bearable for all involved. The authorities are increasingly aware of the growing number of Singaporeans wanting a more manageable pace of life. *With the feedback from consultation sessions with various sectors of the public under the auspices of Our Singapore Conversation and the reactions to the slightly misunderstood Population White Paper, certain policies have been enacted to help Singapore residents. A five- day work week has been recommended for civil servants so that weekends can be spent with their families. Various companies are also providing employees various avenues to go on sabbaticals to recharge as well as providing options to work from home and various other flexi- work arrangements. Women are also choosing to stay at home and sacrifice their careers.*
- **Results of these governmental schemes are questionable:** however the benefits of such schemes are still yet to be seen. Measures only seem to only superficially alleviate the stressors highlighted by people, *the government has pledged to build more childcare centres and provide couples with more favourable maternity and paternity leave arrangements. Unfortunately, these measures seek to send a message that the pace of life cannot be changed and that we can only learn to deal with and to adapt to the present pace of life. The increasing costs of living* in terms of buying a property and buying a car seem to suggest that there is no option but to work harder to earn more in order to afford material goods in Singapore. There is a concerted effort by the government to allow people to better manage a fast pace of life, but its effectiveness is **heavily dependent on the relative premium the populace places** on keeping afloat economically.

Materialism

- **Importance of material possessions:** While it is undeniable that many draw their meaning for their lives from religion, many others **have also found meaning in material possessions**. Many in this group strive for material comforts like houses and cars, in part because it gives on an aura of superiority over others. Material wealth is also an indication of personal success. How well they do in school will determine the kind of jobs they can undertake in a meritocratic society (like Singapore) which further determines their ability to afford what is deemed the mark of success. **Materialism has contributed to the constant unhappiness that people in Singapore experience.** *If the latest Happy Planet Index is anything to go by, Singapore is ranked 90th out of 151 countries surveyed, with Hong Kong being the only Asian country to be ranked lower than itself in the 102nd position.* Perhaps it is this unhappiness and the need for meaning in their lives that religion and spirituality are so central to the Singapore society.

Pragmatism

- **Sacrifice of culture and heritage in the pursuit of economic growth:** The economy is the lifeblood of any country, especially for nascent ones such as Singapore. Before turning our minds to other issues such as political diversity and cultural development, we had to first **secure the financial foundation that would paved way for our continued survival**. Our history thus bears the marks of numerous instances, where the **exigencies of economies triumphed over and over**. **One notable sacrifice at the altar of economic prosperity is the Chinese dialect.** The rise of China, following Deng Xiaoping's 1979 policy of liberalisation, would meant that the various Chinese dialects would not **serve us as well in our transactions with China** as would Mandarin, the variant employed in Chinese state and business functions. For the sake of economic benefit, Chinese dialects were (and still are) banned in state media and Mandarin Chinese was introduced as a mother tongue in schools. Denied an official presence in our linguistic ecosystem, them

have slowly but steadily declined in prominence, taking with them the culture and identity of the dialect groups.

- **Economic growth to give Singapore an edge over her neighbours:**
Singapore has opted in favour of economic considerations whenever necessary to maintain advantages over our neighbours. Singapore exists in a fiercely competitive region: our Southeast Asian neighbours, while ostensibly our trade partners and strategic allies, are also constantly on the lookout for **opportunities to encroach on the economic activities previously dominated by Singapore**. In response, the Singaporean government has taken steps to maintain our advantage in these respects, even at the expense of other concerns. *One such instance is the development of the Integrated Resorts here, to boost our tourism revenues. Thailand and Malaysia have started in earnest to attract a larger share of tourists in the region. Singapore, for whom tourism comprises a full quarter of its GDP, could not simply stand aside and allow this to happen. In response, it chose the Integrated Resorts, casinos-cum-amusement-parks to serve as tourist hotspots on a regional and even global scale.* **Despite furious national debate and controversy over the possible moral implications** - outraged Singaporeans warned the problem of gambling and the corruption of youth - **financial concerns triumphed once again with only blunt measures**, such as an entrance fees for locals, imposed.

- **Money over morals:** In our pragmatic society today, the choice of money over morals echos even more powerfully and insidiously on an individual level. Numerous cases of corruption and embezzlement over the past decade has proven that money-making is the primary and sole consideration. *One such example is the mismanagement of charities and religions, where T. T. Durai spent hundreds of thousands from the National Kidney Foundation on personal luxuries, Ming Yi misappropriated millions of dollars in loans from Ren Ci Hospital and Kong Hee allegedly misused \$50 million of City Harvest Church's money to further his wife's pop music career.* In each of these cases, the individuals involved betrayed those under their care, as well as **the faith of those who had contributed to them**, in exchange for **personal enrichment**. More recently, public servants in the government sector have **displayed similar venality**. Of these instances, the most notable and ironic is perhaps that of the Corrupt Practices investigation Bureau officer Edwin Yeo, who embezzled \$1.7 million dollars from the anti-embezzlement agency to fund his gambling habit. His financial gain here meant not only the **loss of confidence** in Singapore's **reputed incorruptibility**, but it also is a direct blow against the **legitimacy of Singapore's public sector**.
- **Singaporean mindset to prioritise monetary considerations:** Singaporeans are famously driven by the notion of "kiasu" or "afraid to lose". Success or failure, in this matter, is determined entirely by material factors. The clearest indicator of the emphasis on financial and material gain can be located in our schools. Students often report a great deal of familial and societal pressure to take up professional courses, in order to become a doctor or lawyer. The converse corollary - "if it doesn't make money, don't do it" - is true as well: **pursuits in the arts are derided as dilettantism and a waste of time and money**. As a result, *we see a notorious decline in students taking Literature at the secondary school level, as well as the growing gulf between the numbers of students in the Science and the Arts streams in junior colleges. Similar doubt was raised when the Yale-NUS Liberal Arts College was proposed and then inaugurated.*

Singaporeans expressed consternation that such a project was thought feasible in our society, and disbelief that a broad-based education such as the college would prepare Singaporeans adequately for the “working world”. All this reflects a society that - perhaps due to decades of governmental influences - values economic considerations over any and all other concerns.

Less Pragmatic

- **More efforts put into other non-material aspects:** Singapore has started exploring the possibility of **satisfying its citizens’ non-material desires**. As a country, we have been at the peak of economic development in the Southeast-Asian region almost since the day of our independence. At present, this translates to a material standard of living far higher than any of our neighbours. With such achievements firmly in hand, the government has increasingly recognised both our ability to and the necessity of spending money - instead of making it - in order to **accumulate non-material benefits for our society**. *An example of this would be the gradual intensification of efforts poured into the arts, in terms of both logistical and financial support. The MCCY is redeveloping the Victoria Theatre and Concert Hall. At the same time, it has set aside \$200 million to match private sector donations to the arts. MCCY is also attempting to better preserve our heritage, with \$147 million earmarked for maintaining national monuments and refurbishing museums.* These efforts that the government have put in signals that the government is moving **in a different direction, towards the satisfaction of both the material and non- material desires of our population**.
- **Construction of a more inclusive society:** The government has also recently embarked on the construction of a more **inclusive society, even at the expense of our budget reserves**. In the past two years, the government has been made increasingly aware of the strains that continued economic growth **have placed on the fabric of our society**. To rectify the fact that such gains have been unequally distributed, it has shifted its attention from **sustained**

profit-making to more inclusive measures. *Lower income families have received greater GST rebates in the Budget, in order to more equitably distribute the fruits of progress. Similarly, new rules and regulations have been implemented to protect lower-income workers: new mandates regarding minimum salaries - previously a taboo subject in Singapore - have come into play for cleaners and security guards, who now stand to make as much as 15% more than before. **The Pioneer Generation Package** introduced in Budget 2015 aims to provide financial benefits to senior citizens, especially those who may have been neglected or sacrificed in Singapore's push for economic success. Singapore is also **reducing its focus on monetary gain** in favour of preparing for its greying population, by increasing eldercare facilities and initiatives. These measures represent a willingness on the part of the government to slow down the further accumulation of wealth, in order to create a more **inclusive society**.*

- **Individuals are more concerned about non-monetary aspects of life:** More Singaporeans are displaying a desire to trade continued financial growth for the **fulfilment of other needs and wants**. Even as the machinery of the bureaucracy slowly rumbles to life, Singaporeans individually are already a step ahead. Much of the government's initiatives regarding **inclusivity**, *for instance, had their genesis in the initial protests and petitions from the public in the newspapers forums and Meet-the People sessions. In addition, there was widespread decrying of the government-commissioned Population White Paper in 2013 due to the outrage of Singaporeans. The Paper approached the future growth of our population from an economic perspective, and advocated the growth of our population by 38% to 6.9 million by the year 2030.* Such a scenario will not only **strain our country's infrastructure, a strong concern given our limited land and resources, but will also dilute our national identity**, since half of the 6.9 million will be foreigners. The subsequent protests, which forced the government to reconsider its stance, signified that the average Singaporean had progressed **beyond merely monetary concerns**, and would in fact sacrifice them for ideas **as abstract as unity and identity**.

Literature

- **Poor career prospects:** The study of literature is commonly perceived as a subject that inevitably leads to poor career prospects. The decline in popularity of literature or humanities subject as a whole have clearly projected the perspective that linguistic subjects are **less likely to pave a successful career route**. This is especially so in today's **profit-driven economy** where governments push for labour productivity in the finance and business sector that is the key driving force of the country's economic growth. *Hence with vast career opportunities in the finance and technological industries, it is no wonder that the top ten best paid jobs in the world come from science-related or finance sectors on the list by the office of National Statistics 2013 while jobs related to humanities were placed near the bottom.* Therefore, in the **face of reality and the need to survive**,

many high school graduates take on the finance and science majors that have better career prospects. This has caused literature and humanities as a whole to suffer the discrimination of this **profit-driven society**. Consequently, the study of literature is dismissed as an **indulgent option** that few can afford when it is irrelevant to the professional working world.

- **Importance to national identity:** largely due to its quaint nature, literature is useful in preserving ancient cultural values and anchoring a sense of **national unity** against the waves of **modernisation and globalisation**. Countries no longer hold on to their unique and distinct cultural values as cities are evolving into a big melting pot for different cultures, values and nationalities. Literature, hence becomes more important than ever, in helping citizens **to stay rooted to their unique heritage in this ever-changing globalised society**. *Singapore, while often being criticised for lacking cultural exports, in fact is home to many local literary works that accurately reflects their **distinctiveness and multicultural society**. Michael Chang “Army Daze” illustrates the mandatory National Service that every Singaporean son has to go through. Book such as Arthur Yap “The Space of City Trees” or Simon Tay’s City of Small Blessings” are books that revolve around the **everyday life as a common Singaporean**, depicting the various emotions that every other Singaporean shares, portraying the **shared yet unique identity the island has**. Hence, cultural values and histories are **immortalised in literary works** to be shared and passed on to enrich man’s heritage.*
- **Critical thinking skills:** The study of literature has always been a conduct for the **development of critical thinking skills**, thus exposing them to various characters and cultivating their **understanding of life**, which will be relevant in today’s ever changing and fast paced society. Amid the numerous competing influences on modern youths, the study of literature stands out as a timeless way of developing critical thinking skills. *In Singapore, the A level Literature syllabus invites students to examine the relationship between the **individual and society** through texts from a broad range of time periods and locales. Although many methods of top-down dictation to students exist, literature is unique in that it **engages the cognitive skills of students**, allowing them to come to their own conclusions, rather than dictating these conclusions to them. perhaps more so than in other subjects, students of literature consider many varied perspectives and learn to **appreciate ambiguity**. The study of literature incorporates elements*

of sociology, history, psychology and other diverse fields, making it a **rich area for critical exploration**. Especially since the winds of change are blowing more strongly than ever now, navigating the modern world requires the **critical thinking skills that the study of literature hones**.

- **Reflection of how much has changed:** literature serves as a **barometer of societal evolution**, and allows us to take a macroscopic view of how our society has changed over time. Literature serves as a continual measurement of our society in many ways. Literature often describes daily life and the routines we go through and describes the concerns we face on an everyday basis. It therefore portrays the environment we live in. in the past, life in Singapore as depicted in literature often includes kampongs and shophouses, now it is dominated by HDB flats and condominiums. *In the past, poets such as Edwin Thumboo in Ulysses of the Merlion described the Merlion as “salt-manned, scaly, wondrous of tail, touched with power”.* Singaporean poetry was **wrought with imagery relating to our burgeoning independence and nationalistic pride**. Now, *having been assured of a stable economy and a strong nation*, we turn our eyes towards **concerns on the horizon**, such as population growth and immigration, economic pragmatism vs idealism. Literature **forms a distinctive montage of our growth as a nation, individually and as a community and country**. This makes literature important because it provides us with a good way of **understanding our culture, both past and present** and the **cultural forces that shape the way we have been and the way we are**. It also allows us to understand our past, and therefore realise what is worth cherishing by being able to form a **human connection with artifacts and narratives of the past**.

History

- **Preventing history from repeating itself:** The study of history remains relevant because it is one of the key ways through which our **critical faculties as a race are shaped**. There have been many prominent examples of how history has shown us how to prevent future crises. *With the benefit of hindsight, the events of the September 11 have set in motion a series of counter- terrorism actions that*

has in turn prevented many more threats to global security. In December 2001, Richard Reid, a self-professed follower of Osama Bin Laden, hid explosives in his shoe and attempted to light a fuse on board a flight towards Boston. He was apprehended and stopped by security forces and flight attendants in an intervention only made possible by **heightened security measure and improved flight security awareness**. The devaluations of currencies and runaway inflation caused by the **Asian Financial Crisis** led to financial and economic convulsions throughout Southeast Asia in 1997. Nonetheless, as Singapore recovered from the crisis, she took away many lessons about keeping a closer watch on asset and property bubbles. In the recent 2008 Financial Crisis, following the bursting of the US housing bubble, the Singapore government, **drawing from its experience in 1997**, withdrew money from Singapore's reserves to prevent the Singapore economy from sliding into another recession. The lessons of history are still **deeply imprinted in our collective consciousness**, and serve as **shaping influences of our current policies**. In this way, the changes in today's world have done little to erode the relevance of history.

- **National identity:** An appreciation of one's country's history is integral to the formation of a personal and collective national identity. History, especially in fledgling states, has always been a key resource around which national identities naturally coalesce. *The Maria Hertogh and Hock Lee Bus riots of the 1950s were incorporated into Singapore history lessons to **inculcate in students the importance of racial and religious harmony**. Through the lessons racial instability taught in many history and social studies classes throughout the country, students began to better understand the meaning behind events such as Racial Harmony Day and the **constant focus of racial harmony in the Singapore social fabric** that has sought to seek equality 'regardless of race, language and religion'.* The Ministry of Education revamped the lower secondary history syllabus in 2014 to relieve students of the notion that Singapore's history began with Raffles' arrival. Animating this overhaul is the idea that trees with

shallow roots are easily felled - Singaporean students should have an idea of the history of the land in order to feel a strong sense of national identity.

- **Singapore's diplomatic ties:** history has taught us that helping countries rebuild after war, even though they might be the ones who started it, will lead to more peace and stability, rather than simply seeking revenge and retribution. *For example, even after the atrocities of World War II, Singapore worked closely with Japan after our independence to build Singapore's economy. On 21st October 2016, Singapore and Japan recently celebrated 50 years of diplomatic ties between Japan and Singapore in Paragon Shopping Centre. The event was graced by Minister for Social and Family Development Tan Chuan Jin, Japan's Ambassador to Singapore Kenji Shinoda, as well as representatives from the Singapore and Japanese government and business communities.* Singapore understands the need for cooperation and the **importance of diplomatic ties which allows for long term benefits, while conflict only serve to weigh down the country. It would be in the best interests for all countries** to look past the atrocities committed against it and seek the **most viable avenues for collaboration** as it would only lead to positive result]

Habit of complaining

- **Complaining without concrete solutions:** Whining is a commonplace, unpleasant habit of the modern man. The frequency and prevalence of such a culture may only **perpetuate frustration, angst and displeasure** if no further action is taken by both the people and the authorities. This is largely applicable to Singapore where complaints are merely rants which rarely translate to concrete action. There is a **general consensus amongst Singaporeans** that we are people who are quick to lament about an array of issues ranging from the trivial to that of national concerns. The prevalence of **online forum sites** which focus on raising the problems without finding solution solutions clearly shows how much of a national pastime 'complaining' has become. *Many of which points to social concerns that warrant attention and improvement,s such as transportation and cost of living where complaints on SMRT failure, ERP charges, housing and medical care have been made by Singaporeans.* It has been acknowledged that Singapore's **infrastructure has not kept up with the population growth**. At the very most, an online petition is initiated without actually doing anything to seek understanding and compromise by debating with others face to face. Different camps remain as polarised as hey were at the start. There also seems to be a growing **sense of entitlement** among Singaporeans who are used to have problems being solved for them. It is therefore ironic that people who complain about the intervention of authorities in their private lives also demand the authorities solve and address whatever problems that have emerged.
- **Complain with constructive feedback:** Singaporeans do not necessarily complain without **providing constructive feedback**. There are positive signs of Singaporeans taking action to **address problems** that they see in society through *special interest groups such as the Nature Society, Transient Workers Count Too and various charities and organisations.*

- **Complaining to express one's grievances:** Complaining is a **helpful expression of discontent** and an articulation of grief and unhappiness. In many cases, complaining can be impulsive and emotional, and not always met with constructive action. In their attempt to vent their frustration, **angered, derogatory and hurtful words** can be used irresponsibly. Coupled with **exaggerated or twisted facts**, the complaints can potentially be **socially irresponsible and divisive**. This is applicable in Singapore's context, where **social media has been misused as a platform** which incurred inter-racial and inter-religious tensions. Some examples *would include Amy Cheong's Facebook post on the noise generated from the customary void-deck setting of Malay weddings and STOMP users' trigger-happy snapshots of unaware members of public, in the name of citizen journalism to draw awareness to disgraceful public misconduct*, which often bear no consideration to the individuals whose privacy may be intruded without their knowledge. Therefore, the use of online media to **vent personal grievances or irrational emotions** has led to **destructive consequences when insensitive opinions are voiced irresponsibly**.
- **Productive complaints:** There has been productive complaints and responsible usage of social media. *The recent haze situation saw online users come together to distribute N95 masks to the poorer households and construction workers, in view of the complaints of many citizens. Other examples include pro-activeness on the part of Singaporeans to include the online appeal to rally support for the recent MDA revised regulation to tighten control on online blogs.* It seems that as Singapore society **grapples with the phenomenon of a more active civil society**, taking action in response to complaints is slowly becoming a habit.

- **Complaints resulting in change:** The ultimate purpose of complaints is to **seek change and improvement**. Complaints can definitely be used to address and rectify certain perceived social failures and evils. **Complaints have indeed served as constructive feedback in Singapore**, serving as a form of **checks and balances to prevent complacency**. *The outcry amongst Singaporeans after the major MRT breakdowns in December 2011 as well as subsequent failures of the system were seen as a wake-up call for SMRT as well as SBS Transit. In addition, Singapore's ongoing campaigns of National Conversations" is a prime example of constructive complaining, as complaint takes on the form of feedback to and fruitful dialogue with the Government. This might lead to raising awareness about a plethora of problematic issues which might then be acted upon. Hence, this form of complaint may be vital for the survival of a democracy, as the voices of the citizens are heard.*
- **Useless complaining:** Not all complaints are constructive in Singapore because there might be times when venting **degenerates into nitpicking** that results in more problems for the leaders. *In the wake of the recent haze situation, complaining would have been pointless, owing to the fact that it was something which the Singapore government had little control over. The situation needed to be handled with constructive solutions, and not complaints.* There might be those who feel that **without rectification**, a complaint is just a useless whine, and mere articulation might lead to a domino effect, with everyone just piling onto the list of complaints, without any attempt at **seeking out solutions**. As Singapore transitions, people need to learn how to be **more proactive**, rather than depend on others for solutions.
- **Complaining as a unifying force:** The act of constructive complaint can serve as a **catalyst to large-scale social changes**. This is largely applicable to Singapore as some forms of complaint do **unify the fabric of a nation and reinforce certain values which Singapore holds dear**. *There was widespread complaints against Amy Cheong, who passed racist remarks about the Malay*

community on Facebook. The complaints against her strengthened Singapore's forte as a multicultural society based on mutual respect and harmony. Racial harmony is a defining feature of Singapore's national fabric, and it is important to complain against words or actions which **threaten to destabilise this action.** Therefore, it can be seen that complaints against unacceptable behaviour is a means to reinforce the crucial values which the country is founded upon, ensuring that the community **remains intact and national solidarity is maintained.**

Handicapped

- **Social stigma and unequal opportunities:** There is insufficient professional expertise to meet the needs of the disabled. *The disabled often face direct or indirect mockery of their disabilities in public, who may not be as understanding. The disabled often have the inability to follow group discussions or fail to hear what their teachers say in conventional schools. In addition, there is insufficient closed captioning on free-to-air TV channels.* While there is **increased awareness and empathy for the needs of the handicapped** in Singapore, a **social stigma is still attached to the dearth of normal physical or mental ability.** Social attitudes are inherently resistant to change and people often do not express or demonstrate their care and concern. In addition, as the cost of living in Singapore rises inexorably, the lower-income families who have a handicapped family member to look after often struggle financially and emotionally in the prolonged palliative care, which translates into **heavy financial burden** where additional expenses have to be used to undergo expensive medical treatment and therapies. It is unavoidable that there will always be a **social stigma attached to** handicapped people, and these people will never have equal opportunities as normal people do. Unless **technology can one day negate the physical or mental deficiencies in handicapped people,** there is no way to **eliminate this stigma of level the playing field.** Thus, rather than criticising the existence of such unavoidable circumstances,

society should instead focus its energy and resources into minimising and mitigating the burden placed on handicapped people and their families.

- **Special education facilities:** Special schools for students with intellectual and visual disability, as well as autistic students are established to cater to the needs of the handicapped in Singapore. *Examples of these schools include the Pathlight School for autistic students, Canossian School for the hearing impaired and Lighthouse School for the visually impaired.* Although some might argue that putting handicapped people into special schools is a form of **discrimination, as it deprives them of an opportunity for a conventional education and hence limits their potential.** However, placing handicapped students in conventional schools would only **hamper their chances to be a productive member of society** as they will naturally be disadvantaged in a system **tailored for non-handicapped students.** Therefore, actively segregating the handicapped students from non-handicapped ones is not necessarily an undesirable form of discrimination, but is actually necessary if society wishes to **maximise the potential** of such people and **equip them with the means to work and support** themselves in the future.

- **Employment opportunities:** There are also **employment opportunities for the handicapped in Singapore**, where institutions such as the *Bizlink Centre Singapore for those with visual disability as well as Centralised Marketing Service to provide jobs for the physically and visually disabled*. In addition, after a horrific shipboard accident in December 2012 which left Navy serviceman Jason Chee in critical condition and forced him to have three limbs amputated, MINDEF has helped him along in his recuperation process. **Testament to the kindred spirit of ordinary Singaporeans**, hundreds of blood donors also came forward when the Navy asked the public for assistance as he lay in hospital. Most recently, the Navy has allowed him to return to work as an Operations Supervisor at Changi Naval Base. While some employers might be **adverse or hesitant** in employing people with physical or mental impairments, it is perfectly understandable, as handicapped people naturally have certain limitations that might hinder their productivity. However, society should not pressurise or impose regulations for companies to employ handicapped people as such measures would only reinforce society's perception that these people are **liabilities**. Instead, measures to help handicapped people overcome or lessen the extent of their limitations should be adopted so that employers become convinced of their ability to perform as well as non-handicapped workers. Only then, will the stigma on handicapped people be reduced, when they are **not seen as liabilities, but rather, as equal contributors to the nation's workforce**.
- **Transport facilities and accessibility in buildings to aid the disabled:** *In Singapore, there are handicapped-friendly features on public transport which includes ramps on buses, wheelchair spaces and clamps in buses. Wheelchair-bound drivers are also entitled to park in special lots which are often nearer to the carpark exit. In addition, the government implemented the Barrier-free Accessibility Code in 1990 which established standards for disabled-friendly facilities in all newly constructed buildings. The code required architects and designers to design buildings which are easily accessed by the disabled. Moreover, HDB building estates have lifts that stop at every floor to facilitate*

ease of access for the elderly and the disabled. Constructing such facilities is also **integral in reducing the social stigma on handicapped people**, as it enables them to be **less reliant** on family members or society for help. While there is still much of it to be improved, such as removing the need for bus captains to help handicapped people onto the bus, such measures are **a step in the right direction**. Enabling handicapped people to be independent will **indubitably reduce the impression society has of them as liabilities** to the country.

- **Paralympics:** *Singapore recently hosted the 2015 ASEAN Para Games, where handicapped sportsmen, including those from Singapore, competed in various events like Swimming and Athletics. Prominent Singapore Para-athletes include swimmers Theresa Goh, Yip Pin Xiu, Benson Tan and Toh Wei Soong who won several gold and silver medals for Singapore.* Such events are **vital in changing the perception of handicapped people, as it serves as platform to showcase their abilities and talents** despite their physical or mental impairments. Furthermore, apart from **eradicating negative stereotypes of handicapped people**, these athletes also serve as an **inspiration** to other handicapped people in the country. It also **raises societal awareness of the handicapped population**, as people tune in to watch the events and get exposed to the varying needs of handicapped people.

National Identity

- **Unity:** A sense of national identity can keep citizens united through a shared experience, traditions and culture. Even though migration is necessary to mitigate the effects of ageing populations in many developed economies, any developed countries and even Singapore are reacting strongly against the influx of migrants. *This is evident from the Population White Paper protest in 2013 in Singapore, where many citizens vented their anger against the pro-immigration policies, which they **conceded to be necessary for economic growth**, at the expense of the erosion of local culture.* This **sense of national identity needs to be carefully managed** as this could turn into a sense of **xenophobia**, where foreigners are discriminated against.
- **Extreme nationalism:** Even though migration is necessary to mitigate the effects of ageing populations in many developed economies, many developed countries and even Singapore are reacting strongly against the influx of migrants. Racism and xenophobia are at an all-time high even in famously-tolerant countries. *Singapore witnessed its first riots since 1964 at Little India, when a crowd of hundreds surrounded a coach which knocked down and killed an Indian national.* While the destruction by disgruntled migrant workers were massive, the **subsequent clampdown and public backlash was unprecedented.** National identity is often **espoused as a good virtue to practice**, but when taken to the extreme, it forms a far-right political stance that splits a country into an “us versus them” scenario, which inevitably **descends into mistrust** and even violence.
- There are many countries which do not allow dual citizenship. Singapore’s context is complicated by historical reasons, such as tensions with our neighbours as well as **ethnic reasons** where Singapore is the only Chinese majority country in a region that is dominated by Malay Muslim populations. Furthermore, *the need for all healthy males to serve National Service complicates the issue of dual citizenship.* Historically, Singapore would have to

go to war with our neighbour Malaysia if they were to shut off our water supply. Considering that **many Singaporeans have family ties with Malaysians, the notion of dual citizenship would not help our security** and the need for an armed force willing to battle with Malaysia. There is also a **fear that should dual citizenship be allowed, many people would leave Singapore in times of crisis rather than stay**. This could be due to Singapore's youth as a country, and the **many options available to Singaporeans elsewhere**. Therefore, Singapore has reservations to allow for dual citizenship as it may **threaten the social harmony and the solidarity** of the country.

- **Importance of a sense of belonging:** National identity and nationalism are found in communities where people are emotionally invested in. if this **sense of identity fails, then the idea of a nation fails**. This is an especially prevalent issue for countries which just gained their independence and are still **grappling with a sense of belonging and identity**. The need for a **common identity and spirit** in Singapore is so strong that the government invests a lot in the education systems and the **maintenance of common spaces** so that Singaporeans of various ethnic and religious groups can and will **interact**. The need for a common identity is clearly seen in the *National Education initiative by the Ministry of Education to educate the young. The presence of Racial Harmony Day, the singing of the National Anthem every morning, and the recitation of the pledge every morning by school children has helped in some way to build this sense of spirit*. Therefore, to **cultivate a sense of belonging and patriotism from young**, with a special emphasis in formal education, is a **necessary step to solidify national solidarity**. This is especially crucial for a young, multi-cultural society like Singapore which is **dependent on the racial and religious stability** of the country in order to prosper and survive in future.

- **Foreigners diluting our national identity:** However, the common identity that Singaporeans has fostered is complicated by the need for new citizens and migrants. While new citizens have shown their **loyalty by accepting citizenship and engaging in various activities** in grassroots organisations and in their communities the issue of Permanent Residents (PRs) might be an **area of contention**. *This is because PRs have been known to use Singapore as a **stepping stone** in their quest for **better opportunities elsewhere**. The institution of National Service is also a sore point since healthy male citizens must give up two years of their time for full-time service, and about 3 weeks each year for reservist training. While second generation PRs are expected to do NS, they often **forgo their citizenship and move on to greener pastures**.* Therefore, it seems that there is a conflict between the recognition of the **importance of developing patriotism among local citizens**, as well as **balancing the pragmatic need** of the country by inviting foreign immigrants which might potentially alter the social zeitgeist of the country. If nationalism is taken to the extreme, Singapore could suffer if we are projected as a society that does not welcome migrants. Our **reputation as a cosmopolitan and stable society will be threatened**, and possibly cause irrevocable damage economically and socially.
- **Responsibility as a citizen:** Because of Singapore's small size and population and its **highly wired society**, where all **personal information is stored and accessible** by the authorities, legal and moral responsibilities are easier to enforce. *In the case of National Service, all healthy males are required and often tracked with regard to their service in the armed forces, the police force or the civil defence. Failure to serve will result in **heavy punishments** such as fines or even a stint in military prison. With the new voluntary National Service scheme, women and new citizens can volunteer to serve in the Singapore Armed Forces for a few weeks each year.* In terms of **civilian responsibilities, people were easily tracked, monitored and kept under quarantine** during the SARS crisis in 2003. Individuals who broke quarantine were quickly tracked and taken to task.

Hence it is clear that being a citizen in Singapore is **accompanied with civic responsibilities and moral obligations to adhere to** the laws and regulations legislated by the government. This is because **non-compliance** to these laws, rules and norms might **threaten the social fabric of the country**, which is of paramount importance to Singapore which is heavily dependent on the limited size of our population.

View of the majority

- **View of the majority might not be right:** Letting the majority take control and helm decisions, it might not always lead to the **most desirable outcomes**, as majorities tend to **lack the expertise or relevant skills of experts**. Many issues are **highly complicated** and require a consideration of a **multitude of factors and a certain degree of knowledge**. For instance, when making political decisions, governments cannot always assume that the view of the majority is the right one, as the masses are not usually not well-informed or **competent in the field of governance**. If fact, the choices the majority makes might not be the best for the country, as what may actually be beneficial for the country in the long run, might be **unpopular with the masses due to short term sacrifices**. *For example, while many have called up on the Singapore government to increase welfare spending for the poor and unemployed, and to raise taxes on businesses and the wealthy, the government **has remained adamant and refused to pander to such demands***. This is because while doing so might increase the well-being of the population in the short term, it is **potentially devastating in the long run as the government becomes depleted** and businesses pull investments out of the country. Complex decisions often **cannot be effectively evaluated by laymen** who lack complete understanding of the entire picture, and instead base their opinions on the limited information they obtain from the media or people around them. Hence, the majority is not always right, as they may not be **cognizant of information that is necessary for making the best decision**, especially when matters of high complexity, like politics, are involved.

Fear

- **Inhibits success as it stifles creativity:** Fear can be deleterious when it inhibits **society's potential for development and positive change**. Fear has the ability to impede society's progress and development when it discourages creativity and initiative. *For example, Singapore's education has been criticised for instilling a **fear of failure** in children, which has been linked to **lower-levels of creativity and risk-taking in the workplace**. According to a Straits Times survey, 36% of the children surveyed indicated failing tests and examinations as their greatest fear, compared to 17% who considered parents dying as their greatest fear.* As a result, Singaporean students have turned to **rote-learning, memorisation and cram schools** for the sake of acing examinations, severely reducing the **fecundity of creativity and innovation** as children lack time to explore and develop personal interests. **This does not bode well for the country's economy**, as creativity and innovation are traits that are essential for **continued economic vibrancy and success**, especially in today's competitive environment.
- **Turning fear into an advantage:** Fear can strengthen social solidarity and resilience when it is successfully overcome. While in some instances, fear manifests itself in the form of discrimination and violence that weakens social stability, fear actually offers us the unique opportunity **to overcome it**, which would eventually serve to **improve social stability and resilience**. *For example, with ISIS successfully radicalising and influencing Muslims around the world to conduct terrorist activities in their respective countries, one would certainly expect the **fear of ISIS to polarise and divide** non-Muslims and Muslims in societies.* However, despite the existence of fear in multi-racial Singapore, it was not able to polarise and divide the country along racial and religious lines. On the contrary, Singaporeans **overcame the fear stemming from extremist activities abroad**, and instead took **initiatives to enhance racial and religious understanding in the country**. Thus, while some countries have **allowed fear to polarise their societies**, Singapore has instead **turned fear into an advantage** by perceiving it as a need for **greater solidarity and cultural acceptance**. Therefore, fear can be a **catalyst for greater social stability and**

resilience with the correct attitude. Whether fear leads to discrimination and social instability, or greater social solidarity and resilience all depends on how it is perceived and managed in society.

Privacy

- **Willingness to share:** The rise of social media increases the vulnerability of confidential information, resulting in the erosion of privacy today. This has led to **unprecedented levels of sharing personal information on a global platform**, due to the ease of use of various social media platforms, accessibility of these social media sites for many wired societies. This is also largely due to a change in mindset about privacy, where people do not mind losing more of their privacy and might even want others to know more about them. This is highly applicable to Singapore, *where 74% of Singaporeans use social media. For example, people seem willing to share an **inordinate amount of information** about themselves, through the posting of photographs, videos and stories on Facebook and Twitter, in a bid to **increase popularity and improve their self-esteem** when they **seek the approval** of their peers on these platforms. Well-known local bloggers such as Xiaxue, Naomi Neo, Rachel Wong and Youtuber Tan Jian Hao have their avid followers on social media for their **perceived narcissistic and exhibitionist online content**.* Such willingness to share has led to the rise in businesses and individuals encroaching on what we previously valued as private and compiling personal information found online to sell to businesses that want to increase the reach of their advertising efforts. Therefore, **self-obsession**, a phenomenon that is especially prevalent among teenagers today, is testament to the fact that individual publicity and **maintaining a popular image** seems to **overshadow the value of privacy today**. This is facilitated by the rise of social media which has provided platforms for the unfiltered display of personal information.
- **Technology has provided tools to ensure privacy:** Technology has provided tools to **safeguard one's personal information**. Organisations and authorities are taking more steps to **strengthen the security** of computerised applications to better protect the privacy of consumers. There is a rise in the **emphasis on information security** and protection of consumers' rights to privacy. *In Singapore, a new consumer data protection framework has been worked out by the Ministry of Communications, Information and the Arts which will cover*

aspects of collection, use and processing, disclosure, retention and deletion of people's personal data. This is to ensure that there are **adequate safeguards** to protect consumers' personal data and **promote greater trust in the private sector**. When the law was passed in parliament in 2012, organisations must justify the purpose of collecting the personal data of the individual, and **obtain the person's consent** for such purpose before collecting the data. Thus, the enforcement of **rules and regulations** to safeguard privacy counters the **potential misuse of technological platforms that expose confidential data**.

- **Misuse of technology:** The use of technology in our everyday life means some sacrificing of what we previously valued as **private due to the necessity of exchanging confidential information for convenience**. The state of technology today necessitates the maintenance of online databases and giving of personal information, where many functions have gone digital, necessitating the keying in of customer information, capturing of important personal information like bank account numbers and credit card numbers. The **need for speed, efficiency and convenience** unfortunately also means the sacrifice of some of our privacy. The heavy dependence on technology has clearly **come at a cost**, evident in the rise of cyber-crime, particularly those related to the theft of personal information. *In 2012, DBS dealt with a spate of cases where money was being skimmed off accounts using ATM machines.* There are also more cases of companies mining personal details of consumers from databases and selling the information to businesses without the knowledge and consent of the consumers. Hence the **inevitability of the abuse of technology** that **encroaches** on one's personal information clearly demonstrates the decline in an individual's ability to uphold privacy.

Empathy

- **Increased exposure to world affairs:** Singapore is increasingly exposed to various causes via the Internet and cable television, **awakening and alerting** many of these important causes in the world. As Singapore **moves into the modern age**, mediums such as the internet and cable television has **brought the world to us**. *Cable television, for instance, through the power of images, have forced us to confront horrors of the world that we would be sheltered from. Channels such as National Geographic that raise awareness on issues of the environment and BBC knowledge that stage debates on various important socio-economic problems of the world educate us as a country, and informs us of the difficulties of the world.* **This has resulted in Singaporeans becoming more aware of global issues.** Its impact extends beyond awareness, where part of the power of the television is in its instant power to display visual images with the **visceral power of convincing individuals**, and reducing space between the viewer and the situation. Such a process has developed a **great capacity for empathy** among Singaporeans for various causes. *This is also seen on the Internet where the interconnectivity of the Internet has brought various social causes to Singapore, such as fighting for women's rights and LGBT rights. Sites such as Tumblr and Twitter propagate these causes as users are able to easily 'share' or 'reblog' what they feel are important social messages.* Overtime, this results in an **increasingly empathetic online society** as they are exposed to these messages. *For instance, there are sites on Tumblr that dedicate themselves to providing advice for LGBT and sites that champion the rights of the minority.* These sites are engaging in how **casual and accessible they are**, influencing many online users to pursue their sites, gaining a **deeper understanding of such issues**. An issue that is severely underrepresented in Singapore is that of ableism, where Singaporeans are not aware that it is a form of discrimination **against those with disabilities**. It is so **insidious** that it infects every aspect of society yet so few are aware of it. *A local school, Raffles*

*Institution, recently published an article about an issue on their online newspaper site Rafflesian Times, where they interviewed 4 differently-abled Raffles students and had them share their experiences. Such engagement is **genuine, touching and deeply influential in raising awareness and empathy** among Singaporeans.*

- **Education system promotes empathy:** The Community Involvement Programme (CIP), was implemented in 1997 by the Ministry of Education to **inculcate a sense of civic responsibility**, with the long term goal of building a **kinder and caring Singapore**. CIP promotes initiative among students in organising their own community projects for causes that they care for. This takes place at all levels of education. *Schools such as Raffles Girls' School and Bedok South Secondary have long term projects with Special Olympics Singapore and Very Special Arts' Singapore respectively, creating **space and opportunities for students to interact with Singaporeans** from different socio-economic backgrounds, developing a sense of social responsibility and belonging.* Furthermore, the structure of CIP mandates a minimum amount of hours fulfilled by each student, ensuring that every student **goes through this learning process**. As a whole, such exposure builds **empathy among students as they become more aware and understanding of some of the social problems** in the society.
- **Politically active:** Singaporeans are increasingly engaged in politics. The heightened political awareness reflects the greater capacity for empathy and understanding in politics. Singaporeans have been **increasingly engaged in political activism** over the years and there has been a **greater presence, both online and offline**, of Singaporeans discussing and participating in political activities. *Rallies are now more populated than ever, where the recent 2011 elections saw one of the greatest turnouts for both PAP and opposition parties, with crowds amounting to the hundreds of thousands in support for their own parties. There is also a **more raucous and dynamic debate** online. Even among the youth, there are extremely high levels of*

*political activism, where activities such as the Singapore Model Parliament held annually seeks to bring youth together in a role-playing activity, where they simulate the workings of our Parliament, and through the process, facilitate **an understanding** of how the Parliament works. With that understanding **comes empathy**, as they are now aware of the intrinsic workings of the Parliament, and the various obstacles and procedures to go through before something can be done. Additionally, they are required to think in the perspectives of politicians, where they have to balance the needs of the party against the welfare of the people. Such dilemmas and difficulties help to build empathy among the youth as they are now aware of the difficulties in politics. In general, a **heightened sense of political awareness leads to greater understanding of the political situation** and the various mechanism involved. This therefore builds **greater empathy** among the society.*

Apathy

- **Environmentally apathetic:** Singaporeans remain rather resistant to caring for the environment and seem to be reluctant to commit to the notion that caring for the environment requires us to put in additional effort. *For instance, various supermarkets have tried to encourage customers to bring their own reusable bags for groceries using plastic bags, which are non-biodegradable, by adding costs to these plastic bags if used.* This has had little success with Singaporeans with many continuing their use of plastic bags as they do not mind paying the extra cost for convenience. The **fundamental problem lies within the mindset of Singaporeans.** As a country, we have not realised the importance of environmental conservation, and hence we remain rather apathetic towards environmental issues. To Singaporeans, these are **distant issues** that do not concern us. We fail to realise the **repercussions** of not caring for the environment. *Even among the younger generation, with green initiatives being implemented in various schools, students generally seem bothered about the inconvenience brought about. There have been initiatives where on certain days in the canteen, there will be no disposables allowed, is a great source of inconvenience as students have to finish their food and drinks in the canteen.* Our **apathy towards the environment is disconcerting** as this could severely **undermine our quality of life** in years to come.
- **Apathetic towards animal rights:** Animal rights remain as a **grey area in Singapore**, where there is no **widespread consensus on the importance of such rights.** To many, **animal rights are a lofty concept** and many refuse to acknowledge that it is important to be humane towards animals. *Earlier this year in January, there was a spate of high-profile cases of animal abuse, including poisoning of stray dogs and attacks on cats. In fact, at an Asian conference on animal welfare, Law Minister Shanmugam cited the growing number of animal abuse cases reported in Singapore and saw it as a cause of concern, looking towards the law for remedy.* The rights of animals are **not well established** in our country today. Many continue to see animals as inferior and believes that they do

not deserve equal or fair treatment. This has resulted in the **lack of awareness and respect for animals**. As Singapore progresses as a society, it is important that we **mature collectively** as well. This comes through **nurturing a sense of empathy for others in society and understanding their needs**. This is especially **pertinent for a society that has become so pluralistic and diverse**. Only when such societies have empathy can they remain harmonious and united. Empathy is the **sole tool we have as a community** in ensuring that people of different cultures, races, beliefs and religions can **co-exist in a space**. This is integral, not just for Singapore, but for the world, as we move towards **globalisation and borders become so fluid** that it is easy for them to move to different areas effortlessly, blending with local culture.

Terrorism

- **Efficient and effective governmental action:** Terrorism has emerged as a **global security threat in the early 21st century** after a series of terrorist attacks shook the world, claiming countless innocent lives and spreading fear. Singapore has not been spared from the **threat of terrorism**. The Singapore government has **coped admirably** in handling terrorism through **timely intervention and pre-emptive action**, allowing us to contain terrorism in Singapore. *In December 2001, a plot by Jemaah Islamiyah (JI) to attack several targets in Singapore, including embassies and Yishun MRT station, were foiled by the authorities. The attack was targeted at the official personnel of the US, Australia, UK and Israel that are based in Singapore. This led to the arrest of 15 people in a month. Over the next few years, more were arrested and many of them were detained under the Internal Security Act. The government subsequently released a White Paper in 2003, detailing the threat of Jemaah Islamiyah and the evidence for the attack plot that was foiled in 2001. The evidence included photographs of the targets, notes and drawings. Following this attack, Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong initiated the creation of Inter-Racial Confidence Circles (IRCC) and Harmony Circles by the People's Association. In 2016, SG Secure was established to educate and train the wider population of how to respond to terrorist threats. There have also been increased CCTV coverage, increased cooperation with Southeast Asian neighbours as well as the creation of a dedicated response team. These measures seek to promote a better understanding between religions and races so as to cultivate a relationship of trust and tolerance*
- **Self-radicalisation measures:** The government also actively monitors individuals who are self-radicalised on the Internet. It **prevents individuals from joining terrorists organisations** in other countries and from carrying out attacks in Singapore. *Abdul Basheer Abdul Kader was arrested abroad in 2007*

*en route to Afghanistan and again in October 2012 after he attempted to join ISIL in Syria. In 2015, two Singaporean youths were arrested for terrorism-related activities. Arifil, one of the two youths, was intending to join ISIL, following which he would carry out an attack in Singapore. Arifil has been self-radicalised after coming into contact with the **propaganda of terrorist organisations online**. The other youth had been arrested for further determination of his extent of radicalisation.*

Capitalism

- **More involvement in community service:** Singapore has become a **more gracious and caring society** because of the **high standard of living that we owe to our capitalist economy**. With more resources and disposable income, *Singaporeans are volunteering more to help their fellow men through various charities such as in the Boys Brigade 'Share-a-gift' donations and the proliferation of blood donation drives in Singapore. Even the government is seeking to redistribute wealth by providing financial assistance to those in need via various policies and subsidies, such as in the Health Assistance Scheme or Housing Grants.* Even though the capitalist mindset has resulted in a **drop in social mobility**, there are sufficient safeguards present in the **education system and government policies** to keep inequality and unethical exploitation of the poor in check.
- **Corporate social responsibility:** In Singapore, there are regulations in place to ensure that any immoral choices of individuals are not left unchecked. The **rise of social media** has forced both the authorities and private enterprises to be mindful of their **responsibilities to the society**. The rise of **corporate social responsibility** as well as social enterprises is a likely result of increasing consumer awareness of the needs to care for one's society. *For example, the ACA has banned some food imports from China in view of possible radioactive waste consumed by seafood, thus indicating that the **health of consumers is of a higher***

priority as compared to profits. Furthermore, it is because of Singapore's strong rule of law and its social stability that many companies set up their offices here. Therefore, it is evident that capitalism thrives where there is a **strong rule of law** and with the **presence of ethical and moral behaviour**. While capitalism reacts to the demands of the people who are free to **express their desires** and can **cater to their whims and fancies**, the Singapore society and authority still ensure that such behaviour is managed with **strict laws, regulations and principles in place** to protect the interests of the consumer to prevent exploitation by unscrupulous profit-making businesses.

- **Society that is more concerned with moral issues:** Singapore has transited from a society **fixated on economic survival** to one that has evolved to **emphasise less pragmatic, moral concerns**. *Despite the threat of economic repercussions, the people did not give the PAP the mandate they wanted in the 2011 General Elections. Having experienced a life without deprivation and with the availability of options in life, the millennial generation are asking for more work-life balance and a move away from the 5Cs of car, cash, credit cards, country club memberships and condominiums to new 5Cs which includes community and compassion.* Some Singaporeans who have attained a very comfortable level of living from professional jobs are seeking other ways for **self-fulfillment through the setting up of social enterprises**, non- governmental organisations or various charities. Many professionals are going on sabbaticals to raise funds for the needy or volunteering in neighbouring developing countries such as Cambodia, Laos and Myanmar. All these instances seem to corroborate the observations that **capitalism, while not a cure for all, is necessary in the establishment of a more moral and caring society** by providing the means for one to **reorder his priorities** from pursuing financial gain to addressing social and moral concerns.

Internet

- **Communication with others, unconstrained by time or distance:** With **increasing mobility and Singapore being a highly globalised city state**, *an increasing number of Singaporeans are working and studying abroad. As of 2014, 212,000 Singaporeans were living overseas, compared with 157,800 in 2004, increasing by more than a third over the past decade.* Given this situation, the internet has **empowered Singaporeans** in communicating with family and friends **regardless of distance or time**. The rise of social media and mobile messaging applications have helped those overseas stay in touch not just with friends and loved ones, but also **stay connected with the developments in Singapore**. *Such internet-based platforms are also commonly used locally Singaporeans, making it easy for us to maintain everyday contact with one another.* These internet-based communication platforms include Skype, Whatsapp, Line, Viber, among others. In a survey conducted by research firm Global Web Index in 2014, 55% of Singaporeans said they use Whatsapp, which Facebook Messenger came in second place with 30% of Singaporeans reporting usage.

- **Superficial online relationships:** Online relationships are superficial, instead face-to-face encounters but instead true friendships are built on **ties of trust, responsibility and give-and- take**. *A survey by marketing firm Rock Publicity revealed that the Singapore Facebook user had an average 320 'friends' in 2012 and a predicted 372 in 2013. Among these several hundred 'friends' that Singaporeans have on social media, not all are real friends whom we share a meaningful relationship.*
- **Social media as a platform to stay in touch with close friends:** Many of our online 'friends' are also real life friends whom we meet on a **regular basis and share many common interests**, with social media just being an **additional platform to keep in touch**. *A survey by Singapore Polytechnic in 2012, found that Singaporean youths prefer to communicate with family, schoolmates and friends face-to-face rather than online.* The Internet is an extension of existing social lives, and not a virtual replacement for the social lives of Singaporeans.
- **Joining communities based on shared interests:** The increasing number and popularity of various Singapore-based forums, blogs and websites dedicated to specific interests have enabled Singaporeans to not only read about, but also participate and contribute to discussions on various topics. *Many of these are related to very Singaporean interests and concerns such as well known food blogs which includes, LadyIronChef, Miss Tam Chiak, Daniel Food Diary and Rubbish Eat Rubbish Grow.* interested Singaporeans trawl through such blogs for reviews on the latest food places and many often contribute comments or even add to lists of food places in the comments section. *Local online websites and forums such as Kiasu Parents and Singapore Motherhood bring together Singaporean parents and their common concerns about parenting and the education system, providing platforms for them to voice their concerns and exchange tips and information. Furthermore, citizen journalism websites such as STOMP, TR Emeritus, The Online Citizen, The Real Singapore and Sgpolitics are platforms for Singaporeans to express their views about national issues*

*and various governmental policies, giving rise to a more vocal political climate in Singapore. Our politicians have also gone online with their Facebook and Instagram accounts to **better connect with Singaporeans**. Such online communication means that politicians and Singaporeans now converse in the present about issues, rather than after decisions have been made, **empowering citizens in Singapore to have a greater say in national developments**. In fact, with the Internet and its various platforms, Singaporeans have been more **participative and vocal** regarding the **direction that the country is moving towards**.*

- **Insensitive comments:** While this is certainly not true of all content or of every Singaporean who posts content online, there have been cases of Singaporeans posting **insensitive and inflammatory content online**. This can be attributed to the **ease and speed** which Singaporeans can post content online, causing some of them to do so **without adequate thought**. *In an interview with TODAY in 2015, Dr Terence Chong, a sociologist, pointed out that “because the Internet allows for **split-second reactions**, the most poorly thought out sentiments and responses are captured for all to see” and that “**instantaneousness, publicness and permanency of the internet tend to accentuate bad behaviour**”.* In recent years, there have been a number of such cases, but Singaporeans have been quick to speak out **against such unacceptable online behaviour and content**, and the authorities have taken action against those whose online content **are deemed to threaten social stability**. *In 2012, Amy Cheong, a former National Trades Union Congress employee, was condemned online for posting racist comments, with the police issuing a stern warning to her as well. In 2014, British expatriate Anton Casey drew a vocal and angry response from the Singaporean public when he posted derogatory comments on Facebook about the public transport system which eventually caused him to lose his job and leave the country. In 2014, Jesslyn Tan, a Miss Singapore Miss Universe 2013 finalist, created a minor ruckus online when she mocked a food stall helper for wearing a shirt with a hole on Facebook. Most recently in 2015, teenager Amos Yee became the target of outrage when he made disparaging remarks in a YouTube video about the late Mr Lee Kuan Yew and of Christianity and has*

since been charged for his comments. While the **anonymity of the Internet has emboldened Singaporeans** to make such comments online that they might not say offline, by the same token, those who speak up against such **irresponsible behaviour** have the potential to unleash vigilante justice on individuals who might not necessarily deserve it.

Knowledge

- **Knowledge to address pressing concerns and make decisions:** In an age of war on terror, we need as much intelligence information as necessary **to make good decisions** to prevent further attacks, or to eliminate the correct targets without causing harm to civilians. This could even involve invading the privacy of citizens. *For example, surveillance measures such as Patriot Act, Internal Security Act, which are punitive measures that governments are authorized to use to identify culprits, terrorists and radicals. Through the use of surveillance to obtain knowledge of terrorists' plot, the Singapore government were able to stop the terrorists and this led to the detention of Jemaah Islamiyah terrorists who were planning to bomb Yishun MRT station*

WELFARE & THE DISADVANTAGED

- FOR OLDER CITIZENS
 - WORKFARE INCOME SUPPLEMENT
 - Scheme for lower-wage older workers that rewards them with CPF (to help with retirement savings) and cash payments (to help with short-term expenditure needs) for their hard work
 - WORKFARE TRAINING SUPPORT
 - Subsidizes courses for these older workers to upgrade themselves and increase employability → increase potential to earn more
- FOR STUDENTS
 - EDUCATION BURSARIES/FINANCIAL ASSISTANCE

- Financial Assistance Scheme (FAS) and Independent School Bursary (ISB) for students from low-income households that covers school fees and transport fees and also provides them with bursaries (monetary grants)
- Tuition previously seen as privilege of rich since it's rather costly, but there are now subsidized tuition programmes in place by Chinese Development Assistance Council (CDAC), Mendaki and Singapore Indian Development Association (SINDA) for poor students who need the extra help
- Straits Times School Pocket Money Fund for students from low income families

- FOR THE DISABLED
 - Special Employment Credit: wage offsets to companies that hire older workers or people with disabilities
 - Disability Employment Portal: Site that provides resources for people with disabilities to find jobs/internships/training programmes
 - Society for the Physically Disabled helps provide employment opportunities and training workshops for employers to learn how to better work with people with disabilities: Over 200 people found employment through them in 2015
 - Singapore Disability Sports Council: Provides opportunities for the disabled to train and excel in sports that they like without allowing their disability to restrict them
 - SCHOOLS IN SINGAPORE
 - Autism: Pathlight school, Eden School
 - Visually/hearing impaired: Lighthouse school
 - Multiple disabilities: Rainbow Centre Singapore

AGEING AND INTERGENERATIONAL CONFLICT

- Statistics
 - Number of citizens >65 years of age has doubled from 220k to 440k from 2000 to 2015 and is expected to reach 900k by 2030

- SG has the highest proportion of older residents and fastest ageing population in Southeast Asia
- Old Age Support Ratio is falling
 - In 1970, 13.5 people of working age (20-64 years old) supported 1 elderly person → In 2015, this dropped to 4.9 → It's expected to reach 2.1 by 2030
- Economic Impacts of Large Elderly Population
 - Increase in demand for healthcare and eldercare:
 - Elderly healthcare cost in Singapore is projected to rise tenfold by 2030, \$51,000 a year per senior citizen
 - Increase in demand for elderly-friendly services/infrastructure in transport, technology housing
 - E.g clutter-free interface
 - Government has to spend more on such infrastructure and development → higher budget and possibly heavier pressure on working population, which could mean higher taxes
 - Focus of economy has to change
 - Moving towards developing medical services and to improve effectiveness of using technology in jobs so people can continue to work even when growing old
- Social Impacts on Elderly Population
 - 42,000 of elderly live alone, making about around one-third of single-person households
 - Rising number of elderly suicides
 - 30% of suicides in Singapore were by elderly in 2014 (126 of them)
 - Many of them reported feeling lonely, with no direction in life, and feel like they're a burden
- INTERGENERATIONAL CONFLICT:
 - Ageism in the Workforce
 - Young to Old: Older workers discriminated against by younger workers because they lack technology skill or because they seem as though they are unable to cope as well as younger workers

- Old to Young: Younger workers discriminated against by older workers because of the impression that they are not experienced or reliable enough
- OVERARCHING IDEA: Communication gaps between generations and lack of understanding towards each other, thus resulting in stereotype mindsets and different values
 - Older workers value experience and a rigid system whereas younger workers are more flexible and 'self-centered' aka don't consult others
- GOVERNMENT SOLUTION
 - Career Support Programme: Government subsidises wages of older workers so firms will be incentivized to give them a try and hire them
 - Raising retirement age: from 65 to 67, provide support for elderly beyond a certain age, especially since life expectancies are long and this also expands the labour force
- OTHER COUNTRY!!!
 - BMW in Germany tested out an assembly line with workers of average age 47 and made modifications to suit them such as providing chairs and larger screens and reducing physical strain needed in the production. As a result, production went up by 7% and absenteeism dropped and the defect rate dropped to 0%! And the project only cost \$50,000
- Abuse of Elderly
 - Financial Abuse
 - Newspaper reports cases of elderly being tricked into selling off their property and giving the proceeds to their children, who promised to care for them, but later on abandoned them.
 - Elderly giving their life savings to children to manage but their children take their money
 - Physical Abuse
 - 2015 case of guy filming his neighbour slapping her mother and hitting her (Lower Delta Rd Block incident)

- Elderly don't know who to turn to to report the misdeed since they're often reliant on the people who abuse them and fear the aftermath
- WHAT THE GOVERNMENT HAS DONE FOR OLD PEOPLE
 - Social programmes
 - Senior Activity Centres for elderly to interact and get support so that they can get out of their homes and not feel so lonely
 - Befrienders: E.g. Lions Befrienders where volunteers carry out home visits for elderly and sometimes accompany them to their hospital visits too
 - Three-Generation flats: encourage multi-generational living and interaction and bonding, especially since it's more affordable
 - Active Ageing Hub: Launched in 2016, aims to provide recreational as well as medical services and a garden for dementia patients to stimulate their senses
 - Multigenerational childcare centres: Elderly engage with children in calligraphy, art and exercise sessions
 - Economic/Daily
 - Various VWOs such as Meals on Wheels provide home food delivery for elderly who are unable to go out or are fairly immobile
 - Government has multiple schemes that provide payouts for low-income elderly, like the Silver Support Scheme or the ComCare Long Term Assistance Scheme
 - Preventive/Medical
 - Home Improvement Programme for seniors provides subsidies for them to install stuff like grab-bars and slip resistant floors for safety
 - Legal
 - Maintenance of Parents Act: People above 60 years old who are not able to support themselves are able to sue their children for a maintenance sum if these children are not currently taking care of them, as a social safeguard against children trying to flee responsibility.

KIASUISM

- A Hokkien term that directly translates to 'scared to lose', which reflects a national attitude of a fear of losing out and engaging in often negative and grasping, sometimes selfish behaviour
- Nominated Member of Parliament Kuik Shiao-Yin calls it a 'toxic arms race', citing the apt example of parents sending their children for tuition classes just because it has become close to a norm in Singapore.
- **NOTABLE EXAMPLES**
 - E.g. in buffets, it is not uncommon to see Singaporeans be afraid that they might not get enough food, and thus, in order to maximize their money's worth, they will take far more food than they can actually eat just so as to not miss out on it. This led to many restaurants implementing waste charges on uneaten food to discourage such selfish and wasteful behaviour.
 - E.g. in 2000, McDonald's launched limited edition Hello Kitty dolls, which resulted in thousands of people queueing for hours, fighting, fainting, traffic congestions due to long drive-thru queues, and even a glass door shattering. It has become a textbook example of Singaporeans' love for queueing and fear of missing out on popular items, and highlights the ugly behaviour that we can engage in when trying to secure our own interests over things that we do not need but simply want for the sake of having.
 - E.g. KiasuParents.com which is true to its name, a parenting forum for parents to discuss examinations and compare schools and share parenting tips to help their children excel. However, this tones down the competitive nature that is often associated with kiasuism and instead presents collaboration!

PARKS & GREEN SPACES

- Singapore Botanic Gardens

- Attained UNESCO World Heritage Site inscription, for having maintained its historic landscape and heritage trees and valuable plant collections extremely well over the last 150 years
- Jacob Ballas Children's Garden
 - Specially for children to learn about and immerse themselves in nature via activities like worksheets and a Sensory corner
- Sungei Buloh Wetland Reserve
 - Opportunity to view migratory species and other interesting flora and fauna around
- Park connectors: one with nature! Lmao

EVENTS

- RACE
 - 2013 Little India Riots
 - Indian construction worker was knocked down and killed by a coach. Soon, people started to gather and it ended up with like ~300 people and they threw dangerous shit like vegetables (and metal grates) at the police officers and SCDF rescuers and overturned police cars and set fire to SCDF vehicles.
 - Turns out the dude was drunk and ran after the bus and fell and it was ruled not the driver's fault but ppl were still pieces of shit anyway.
 - 2014 Anti-Riot Drill
 - Minister for National Development Khaw Boon Wan made an FB post about an hour-long anti-riot exercise at a Woodlands dormitory that involved South Asian workers as the aggressors.
 - Many netizens commented that it was racially insensitive and in poor taste by stereotyping certain racial groups as rioters.
- CONSERVATISM
 - Majority of youths (18-34) were either neutral or for same-sex marriage and gay lifestyles whereas those of the older generation, especially >70, were against it

- Complaint over Cathay Pinkdot advertisement even though it was not actually in violation of any code, but they were advised to remove the tagline 'supporting the freedom to love' because of public sensitivity
- Public outcry over Ashley Madison's attempt to branch into SG in 2013 → petition garnered 13,000 signatures in 2 days and even Minister for Social and Family Development spoke up against it
- SCANDALS
 - NKF Scandal: T.T Durai, CEO of NKF, was found misappropriating donations and funds on his own personal expenses (gold-plated fixtures, first-class trips) as well as under-declaring funds and over-declaring number of patients under their care to solicit more donations. Many regular donors cancelled their donations and the walls of the NKF premises were vandalized.
 - City Harvest Church: Church leaders, including founding pastor Kong Hee, were convicted of over \$50 million of fraud and the use of funds to fund lavish lifestyles and Sun Ho's pop career
- AMOS YEE
 - Charged in 2015 for a video involving hate speech against Christians and insulting, as well as publishing obscene images of LKY. He fled to US to claim political asylum and was granted it, since the Immigration Judge decided that Singapore persecution was actually a move to silence his political opinions that criticized the government hidden behind the guise of maintaining religious harmony → places spotlight on Singapore being a tightly-censored and controlled country with zero tolerance for dissent or opposing viewpoints
- ANTON CASEY
 - In 2014, British Banker Anton Casey posted offensive comments about the SG public transport system on his Facebook account, most particularly calling the commuters 'poor' and referring to the experience as leaving a 'stench of public transport' while accompanied by a materialistic photo of his Porsche. He received death threats and public outcry and had to leave the country although he had been a PR for 12 years. His lawyers also received hate mail and reporters kept trying to contact his friends on Facebook, leading them to have to unfriend him

- XENOPHOBIA
 - Total of 1.4 million foreign workers as of 2017
 - Not In My Backyard: In 2008, 1600 Serangoon Gardens residents signed a petition protesting against the plans to build a foreign workers' dormitory there. Some in the upper-middle-class neighbourhood wondered whether property prices would nosedive and crime soar.
 - 94% of respondents were comfortable working for a local-born Chinese as compared to 74% for a boss who is a new citizen from China.
 - 32.% of residents surveyed felt that prejudice based on nationality has become more widespread now (2014) compared to five years ago

CONTROVERSIAL TOPICS IN SG

- LGBT: Lack of representation in media, 377A
- FOREIGNERS: Spawned the creation of the Singapore First political party that promised reforms to prioritize Singaporeans in the economy and labour sector, in the face of rising foreign talent working in Singapore.
- RACIAL: Amy Cheong's Malay wedding rant, recent Presidential elections being labelled as tokenistic, Channel NewsAsia's documentary that investigated the perceptions of race and racism (was a surprising leap into the contentious but it paid off because it actually conducted a lot of fair and mature conversations about racism in Singapore)
 - 1964 race riot: political and religious tensions between ethnic Chinese and Malay groups at Padang, where 22 people were killed and almost 500 injured → inspired Singapore's drive for a racially harmonious society and it is commemorated every year as Racial Harmony Day and students learn about it in textbooks
 - What SG has done for racial harmony:
 - OnePeople.SG: body that works to promote racial harmony through dialogues and hosts the OPMUN to discuss stakeholders in SG
 - Ethnic Integration Policy in HDB flats
 - Not all racial incidents are bad: Malays at a Malay wedding in Pasir Ris stood up to pay respects to a passing Chinese funeral

- RELIGIOUS: rising tensions against the Muslim population are not completely absent even in our progressive society → Islamophobic behaviour like graffiti was found in public spaces after the Paris Bataclan attack and other ISIS attacks
 - Religious harmony in Singapore: Jamiyah Singapore, Singapore Buddhist Lodge and Taoist Federation Singapore co-organize a Hongbao Distribution every year
 - Maintenance of Religious Harmony Act: allows for a restraining order to be made against a religious authority/figure that has committed the deliberate act of trying to incite religious tensions or use to comment on politics.
 - Maria Hertogh riots: Fight for custody between a Child's Christian Dutch biological parents and her foster Muslim Parents and the courts granted custody to the biological parents and newspapers published pictures of Maria surrounded by Christian symbols → Muslims felt that the law was biased against them and started a riot, attacking Europeans

2019 – Updates

- **Respecting history:** The HDB recently announced that two new Punggol BTO housing estates will pay tribute to Punggol's history as a fishing village and to one of Singapore's earliest zoos, Punggol Zoo. The development will be divided into five thematic zones based on natural habitats such as forest, grassland and shoreline, comprising unique design elements that evince Singapore's historical importance. This reflects Singapore's emphasis on paying homage to its past.
- **The importance of climate change:** PM LHL publicly acknowledged climate change as an "existential threat" to Singapore in his 2019 National Day rally, and that everything must 'bend at the knee' to protect Singapore.

- This marks the defining moment for Singapore's climate war. It is a clarion call for us to understand the climate impact reverberating through our society, economy and geopolitics.
- **The 'why'** – At “just” 1.1 degrees Celsius increase in warming, climate change will cost millions of lives and homes, lead to **acidic oceans** challenging sea-life, droughts, floods, heatwaves ravaging crop yields, as well as mosquitoes reproducing faster and propagating Zika, dengue and other pandemics.
- Singapore's economy has a carbon bent. We emitted 50.9 million tonnes of greenhouse gases in 2014, 27th highest among 142 countries.
- Singapore as a global financial hub should accelerate efforts to leverage and support the essential global transition to a clean, decarbonised economy. Take the lead in Sustainable finance will mushroom, from SWFs and other smart investors divesting fossil fuels and others with carbon exposure, to protect financial returns.
- **Increase in statutory retirement age as reflection of ageing workforce:** from a retirement age of 55, LHL in his national day rally has recently announced that the statutory retirement age is pushed to **63 by 2022**, and 65 by 2030. It means that workers can't legally be forced out of a job simply because their employers want to replace them with younger and cheaper hires, at least not until those already on the payroll hit the statutory retirement age.
 - **Measures to curb against corporate craftiness:** However, this creates problems that must be addressed. While the new rules require employers to offer jobs to existing aged employees eligible for re-employment, employers can adjust the terms of their employment. As 'adjust' is a frustratingly flexible word, this leaves employers free to use that as a get-out clause to arbitrarily cut the pay of workers who hit that “retirement” age.
- **Space Optimizer and Increased Connectivity:** National Development Minister Lawrence Wong recently announced that a 1.4km sky park is set to be built above the Bukit Timah canal, as part of the National Parks Board plan to develop the Bukit Timah – Rochor Green Corridor. The park serves to link Singapore's three national gardens – Jurong Lake Gardens, Singapore Botanic Gardens and Gardens by the bay
- **Rice Media (Singapore's Alternative Media):** Michael Petraeus, a polish national behind Critical Spectator, a commentary blog which recently posted critical opinions on Malay's

Prime Minister Mahatir and positive portrayals of the Singapore way, shot to prominence into the universe of Singapore's alternative news media.

- **Education:** The recent trend being that Singapore schools are moving away from streaming to subject-based banding (SBB), in a bid to improve better social mixing. Two schools, Edgefield Secondary School, and Boon Lay Secondary School, have implemented the SBB two years prior, producing good results. Students generally are more motivated to come into school, as classes are organized by common interests, such as similar CCAs, subject matters
 - By 2024, all schools are projected to convert to a SBB regime.
 - Evaluation (-): Untrue, as ultimately it is argued that the most causal factor for social mixing is the existence of a facilitator (teacher) for strive for social inclusion for kids.
 - Evaluation (-): However, higher banding schools, such as IP and SAP schools, are not involved in the SBB, to ensure a balance of diversity within schools. Such schools are designed more so to focus on academic rigour, justifying the retainment of its old education structure.
- **Global (lack of) competitiveness:** In the recent Channel News Asia documentary "For Food's Sake", Chef Ming Tan observes the stark shift of Singapore's status as a transshipment port for seafood. Over the last 20 years, Singapore has served as a vibrant transshipment port for seafood export market. Seafood factories in Indonesia and Philippines would sell their stock to middlemen distributors in Singapore, who would then leverage its distribution network to on-sell to other countries, such as China and Vietnam. Now, as the aforementioned countries grow and demand greater volumes and variety of seafood export, producers in Indonesia and Philippines now find it economical to export stock direct to the above markets, effectively cutting out Singapore.
 - Ultimately, this highlights the extent of global change, and reinforces the idea that Singapore, as a small nation, must never rest on its laurels in developing oneself.
- **Rebirth of physical stores amidst the hype of e-commerce:** Despite the much documented threat of the death of retail as a result of the rapid emergence of e-commerce, this threat is arguably overstated. Traditional online retailers have recognised the vital significance of a brick-and-mortar store as part of an omni-channel sales medium to attract customers. The idea being that a physical showroom is ultimately still necessary to establish and create a valuable brand image.

- Case in point – Alibaba’s e-commerce platform Taobao has recently launched its flagship brick and mortar store in Funan Digitalife Mall. This emphasises the importance of a physical store to support a company’s brand value. Operating solely on an e-commerce solely risks. The popular woman fashion retailer, Love-Bonito, has also done the same.
- **Iskandar Malaysia: Vision vs. Reality**
 - **What:** The Iskandar region, as a special economic zone spanning southern Johor, was dubbed the “next Shenzhen”. It would leverage its proximity to Singapore, along with the abundant land and cheap labour that Johor had to offer, and be the city state’s “hinterland”, a lower-cost manufacturing hub for its companies. The idea was that Singapore and Malaysia would collaborate to develop the area and offer international investors the best of both worlds — Malaysia’s lower costs of operations and extensive resources and Singapore’s high-tech and service capabilities. The development was projected to attract about US\$105 billion in foreign direct investment and create more than 800,000 jobs for a population of three million by 2025
 - **Problems:**
 - **[1] Overcapacity:** Major developers, both SG and overseas flushed the region with an oversupply of upscale property, owing to virtually unfettered development by Chinese economies. This lead to price softening and sentiment weakening amongst the region.
 - **[2] Political:** Catalytic investments postponed – such as the SG-KL High Speed Rail and SG-Johor Rapid Transit System, which affected the popularity and value of the Iskandar region. In January this year, the scheduled annual meeting of the bilateral Joint Ministerial Committee for Iskandar Malaysia was postponed, following a maritime dispute between Singapore and Malaysia. It looks like investors are going to have to wait a while more for any clarity on the region’s progress
- **PMD bans:** On November 5, the government rolled out a permanent ban on personal mobility devices (PMDs), with strict enforcement starting on the 1st of January. This change was initiated after a series of PMD-related accidents, in which pedestrians were injured, and in more serious cases, the resulting in the death of one cyclist.

- **Of heavy cultural / societal relevance:** The banning of PMDs affect the Singapore society asymmetrically. Here, PMDs remain very attractive as they offer a semblance of the convenience & mobility one gets with a car, without its accompanying price tag. Food delivery workers use PMDs the most - individuals who are supposedly 'unskilled' labourers, who do not earn a lot . In fact, some of these jobs are meant to create a supplementary income as they need the extra money. Putting things into perspective, the ban on PMDs are most poignantly experienced by a marginalised group whose social mobility (and now literal mobility) is constrained.
- **Semakau Landfill - a global success:** Semakau Landfill marks its 20th anniversary in 2019. In conjunction to this, the National Environment Agency also won the 2019 Hassib J. Sabbagh Award for Engineering Construction Excellence, presented by the World Federation of Engineering Organisations, for the development of Semakau Landfill, which was recognised as a model for engineering excellence and sustainable urban development. As a testament to the landfill's capability to keep the surrounding area of Pulau Semakau clean, thriving fish farms, such as Barramundi Asia, have invested millions of dollars in setting up fish farms near the area.
- **Retail training initiative:** The Ministry of Manpower has launched a new initiative called the Job Redesign Place and Train Programme for Retail Industry, as part of ongoing Government efforts to help retail workers upskill and take on higher value roles, in light of the rapid transformation of the retail industry. Retailers will receive salary support of up to 70% for employees placed on the programme for up to three months. Through such a programme, employees will be trained in areas such as web merchandising and digital marketing, on top of their in-store duties.
- **Minimum age for smokers:** The minimum age for smoking will be raised to 20 on January 1, as Singapore further intensifies its efforts to get people to stub out. This will be further raised to 21 on Jan 1, 2021. It is hoped that by progressively raising the minimum legal age for purchase, use, possession, sale and supply of tobacco products, it will prevent youths from picking up smoking by limiting access to tobacco products
 - **Evaluation:** That being said, while such an effort is commendable, it remains a highly broad-brush approach that is susceptible to issues of enforcement, nor does it target the issue at its core - which is essentially one of education.

2020:

- **Licensing scheme for sterilised dogs:** By the end of this year, owners of sterilised dogs will only need to apply for a licence once throughout the life of their pet, said Senior Parliamentary Secretary for National Development Sun Xueling on Wednesday (Mar 4). The new scheme, aimed at encouraging more pet owners to license their dogs, will replace the three-year licensing option.
 - Options for one-year or two-year licences will still be available to provide flexibility to owners, as some dogs may be very old or in critical condition. Pet dogs which are licensed are microchipped and owners have to provide important details such as the place of residence, NParks said, as part of measures to ensure the traceability of animals. I
 - **Evaluation:** Improvement of pet sector regulation as reflective of a broader emphasis to ensure societal stability. Left unchecked and unregulated and unlicensed pets can be a dangerous source of illnesses (i.e. rabies), which is prevalent in other countries with no such licensing regime in place. On a broader level, it reflects Singapore's strong commitment in ensuring societal stability and quality of life for its citizens.
- **Housing accessibility (HDB) in 2020:** During the Committee of Supply debate, the Housing and Development Board (HDB) announced that it will be doing away with Re-Offer of Balance Flats exercises, meaning that most of the unsold Build-To-Order flats left over from Sale of Balance Flats exercises will be offered for open booking.
 - Accordingly, unwed parents above the age of 35 can purchase a two-room Flexi flat in non-mature estates or a resale flat if they are eligible.
 - Unwed parents over the age of 21 can now also buy a three-room flat in a non-mature estate from HDB, compared to a two-room flat previously.
 - **More grants for seniors:** HDB also announced enhancements to the Silver Housing Bonus and Lease Buyback Scheme that took effect immediately.

- The Silver Housing Bonus, which gives a cash bonus to elderly households who downgrade from a bigger flat to a three-room or smaller flat, will be boosted to S\$30,000 up from S\$20,000.
- **More support for those without direct lift access:** Residents in urgent need of direct lift access due to medical conditions or mobility reasons may apply for a S\$30,000 Lift Access Housing Grant to buy a flat with lift access, said Mr Wong.
- **Evaluation:** The continued emphasis of the Singapore government on ensuring that, as far as possible, each citizen (regardless of marital status) is capable of owning one's own house, is a reflection of a broader societal policy at play – that of meritocracy.
- **Climate change (housing):** One-, two- and three-room HDB households will benefit from a S\$24.8 million Climate-friendly Household Package to be rolled out by this year, announced Minister for Environment and Water Resources Masagos Zulkifli on March 4 2020. This will include a one-off S\$150 voucher offered by the National Environment Agency (NEA), to help households living in one- to three-room HDB flats invest in energy and water efficient refrigerator models, he said, making the announcement during the Committee of Supply debate.
 - “Many households continue to purchase one to two ticks refrigerators, partly due to the higher upfront costs of energy-efficient models, without considering the savings from electricity consumption over the long term,” said Mr Masagos.
 - **More led light vouchers:** Mr Masagos also announced that the Switch and Save - Use LED programme, first launched in 2018 for one- and two-room HDB households, will be expanded to all three-room HDB households.
 - As part of the Climate-friendly Household Package, each three-room HDB household will receive a S\$25 voucher to buy LED lights, which are 80 per cent more energy-efficient than incandescent lights and 40 per cent more energy-efficient than compact fluorescent lights.

- Since the programme was rolled out, about 8,700 one- and two-room HDB households across Singapore had used the vouchers and switched to LED light bulbs, said NEA.
- Later this year, NEA will launch a training course to train and certify technicians to handle refrigerants properly, said Mr Masagos.
 - NEA is working with the Institute of Technical Education (ITE) and Temasek Polytechnic (TP) to introduce training courses for household air-conditioner technicians and chiller technicians respectively, it said in a media release.
- **Evaluation:** Such a policy change is a reflection of:
 - Singapore's strong commitment to climate change, not just on a broader policy level, but right down to each and every citizen.
 - Reflects the point that each and every one of us, no matter our income capacity, may contribute substantially towards climate change.
 - **Starting small, thinking big:** While the policy only targets household appliances (traditionally comprising a very low carbon footprint relative to other sectors), it is a first step and a reflection of Singapore's strong commitment towards reaching its goals agreed under the Paris Agreement.

Coronavirus:

- **A little too late?: Minority treatment**

- Gazetting two dormitories as isolation areas is an "enormous undertaking", but the authorities are working hard to ensure the well-being of affected workers, the Ministry of Manpower (MOM) said in a media release on Monday.
- This comes a day after the S11 Dormitory @ Punggol and Westlite Toh Guan Dormitory were gazetted as isolation areas following a spike in the number of COVID-19 cases at the two dormitories.

- Following the announcement, **photos and videos circulating online appeared to show crowded and unsanitary conditions** at the S11 Dormitory, and an ambulance and medical personnel at Westlite Toh Guan.
- The move to gazette the two dormitories as isolation areas has also brought the **issue of foreign worker living conditions into the spotlight**.
 - There are currently about 200,000 foreign workers in Singapore living in purpose-built dormitories like S11 Dormitory and Westlite Toh Guan, said the minister.
 - the latest incident highlighted the importance of high standards at worker dormitories.
- **Evaluation:** The point being that this retrospective policy response by the government dangerously reflects something more sinister – the clear discrimination between low-skilled foreigner workers, who have toiled to build up this country, and its citizens. Surely, the impact of the virus could have been limited if the government had, in the beginning, provided stringent measures as to the quality of worker dormitories.
- **Home-based learning – income inequality?:**
 - For many, when learnt that schools would go into full home-based learning on Wednesday (Apr 8), it would be impossible.
 - These represent the minority poor, who cannot afford laptops.
 - The Straits Times reported on April 8 that a certain Mdm Nor, who noted how difficult it was for her other two kids, who are in Primary 1 and 4, to cope with just one laptop when home-based learning was first introduced on Apr 1.
 - Mdm Nor was initially daunted by the idea, but not since the family **received two donated laptops from ReadAble**, a volunteer group that runs weekly reading classes for children living in the Chin Swee area.
 - The sad reality is that “low-income families who cannot afford to buy a computer or tablet for their school-going children”.
- **The budgets: Unity, Resilience, solidarity – Curbing individualistic, selfish behaviour.**

- At one level, the unprecedented three-in-one Unity, Resilience, and Solidarity Budgets demonstrate the **resolve of Singapore to ensure businesses and households are helped** amid the public health concerns and the economic fallout of the Covid-19 global pandemic.
 - Measures include a 15 per cent property tax rebate for commercial properties, and a half-month rent waiver for tenants under government agencies.
 - Landlords were expected to pass on these property tax rebates to tenants in the form of rental reductions to help them tide over this challenging business environment.
 - The Resilience Budget on Mar 26 provided an enhancement of the property tax rebate through a larger tax rebate and by covering more properties so some qualifying commercial properties will pay no property tax this year, while others will see a rebate of as much as 30 per cent.
- The **socially responsible** landlords duly and promptly passed on the tax rebates to their tenants with no strings attached.
 - For example, retail, food beverage and service outlets at Changi Airport received a 50 per cent rental rebate for six months effective from Feb 1.
 - Initially, Singapore's economic agencies such as Enterprise Singapore tried to bring the tenants and the landlords together and work out how they could share the rebates, especially if 100 per cent is passed on to them.
 - As a result, the Government has on April 7 urgently passed new legislation, the COVID-19 (Temporary Measures) Bill, **to require landlords to pass on, in full, to their tenants the property tax rebates.**
 - To deal with foot-dragging by some landlords who had promised to pass on tax rebates, the new law provides a prescribed timeline for the transfer of the benefit.
 - It will also **prohibit landlords from imposing conditions** on their tenants when passing on the property tax rebates.

- Property owners who fail to fully pass on property tax rebates unconditionally to their tenants "without reasonable excuse" will be guilty of an offence.
- **EMPLOYERS RELUCTANT TO PLAY THEIR PART** Another example of individualistic behaviour we have seen is of some companies not playing their part in reducing the risk of COVID-19 infections as they remained reluctant to implement safe distancing measures at work and have their staff telecommute.
 - The Infectious Diseases (Workplace Measures to Prevent Spread of COVID-19) Regulations 2020 was enacted on Apr 1 to compel employers to implement telecommuting.
 - This was followed by Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong announcing a series of more stringent "circuit breaker" measures to the nation on Apr 3, which included requiring all employers engaged in non-essential services to have their staff work from home for a month.
 - Given the very serious public health threat posed by the COVID-19 disease, it is worrying that the use of the legislative compulsion is deemed necessary to compel employers to implement safe distancing and telecommuting at work.
 - As legislative fiats are not completely effective in inculcating desired norms and behaviour and preventing opportunistic behaviour, the challenge going forward is to better engender cooperation among stakeholders in such challenging times.
- **Singapore's ruthlessness:** A number of instances reflecting Singapore's ruthless response towards the coronavirus
 - **Closure of businesses:**
 - Ten business outlets which had remained open - despite providing "non-essential services" - have been instructed to cease operations, said Enterprise Singapore (ESG) and the Singapore Tourism Board (STB) on Wednesday (Apr 8).

- In a joint media statement, ESG and STB said the 10 outlets included TCM retail establishments, stores selling wellness and beauty products, money changers, mobile phone retail shops, consumer electronics retailers, as well as kitchenware and stationery stores.
- Together, ESG and STB conducted enforcement checks on about 10,700 businesses across Singapore on Tuesday, when the month-long "circuit-breaker" measures took effect.
- **ESG conducted checks on over 9,750 FB and retail outlets in 67 shopping malls, while the tourism board inspected more than 970 tourism-related establishments.**
- **Closure of workplace:** All workplaces except for those providing essential services and those able to operate remotely will be suspended from Apr 7 to May 4 during a month-long "circuit breaker" campaign to curb further spread of COVID-19, said Manpower Minister Josephine Teo on Friday on Apr 3
 - The Jobs Support Scheme, in which the Government co-funds salaries, will be enhanced to help businesses pay local workers, noting that some of these companies' operations will be reduced or ceased during this period.
 - However, food establishments, markets and supermarkets, clinics, hospitals, utilities, transport and key banking services will remain open as they are considered essential services.
 - Evaluation: This is a decisive move at an attempt to eradicate the virus.
- **Full home-based learning for schools:**
 - School will be suspended for about a month from April 8 as part of the stricter measures to curb the spread of COVID-19.
 - Students across all levels, from primary school to universities, including those in special education schools, will shift to full home-based learning until May 4, the Ministry of Education (MOE) and the Ministry of Social and Family Development (MSF) said in a joint press release.

- All pre-schools, kindergartens and student care centres will also be closed, but will provide limited services for children of parents who have to work and cannot find caregivers.
- **Evaluation:**
 - By loaning out nearly 4,000 digital devices to those who did not have them, the government seeks to ensure that those vulnerable families are included in this transition.
 - There remain challenges of transforming your home into a virtual learning environment for children more accustomed to the structures and routines of school.
 - In households where multiple family members share a laptop or desktop computer, and certain online learning platforms are best accessed via such hardware rather than mobile phones and tablets, home-based learning **may put pressure on scarce resources.**
 - **Device sharing:** Parents who use their laptops for work-related tasks will find themselves having to cede access to their children and work around their classroom schedules, even as they scramble to meet their own deadlines.
 - Doubtless, some deft coordination is necessary and parents will find themselves having to strategise device-sharing so that everyone can be online, on time and on task.
 - **Connection:** Parents and children may find it easier to connect over what happens “in school” and this can foster communication and mutual understanding. Home-based learning can encourage parents and children to teach each other how to use technology, thereby creating opportunities for shared media use and familial bonding.

○ **Restrictions on movements and gatherings:**

- As Singapore battles the COVID-19 outbreak, all social gatherings of any size in both private and public spaces have been banned under a new Bill passed in Parliament on April 7
- This would include private parties or gatherings with families or friends not living together, at home or in public spaces such as HDB void decks, said Health Minister Gan Kim Yong.
- Under the COVID-19 (Temporary Measures) Bill, the Government has included provisions to provide the legal basis in order to enforce the enhanced safe distancing measures.
 - Under the Bill, the Health Minister can prohibit events and gatherings or impose conditions on how they are conducted and on the participation in such activities.
 - In addition, the Bill will also allow the minister to restrict individuals' movements and interactions at their place of residence or any specified place, as well as their use of common areas such as void decks.
 - Further, under the Bill, the Minister for Health also has the power to close premises to minimise interactions and reduce the risk of COVID-19 transmission.
 - The Bill will further empower the minister or any public officer authorised by the minister to appoint enforcement officers to take action against individuals, business owners or entities which flout the orders and requirements.
- **Evaluation:**
 - This measure reflects Singapore's ruthless and rapid response towards the coronavirus incident, whereby it regards the incidence and transmission of COVID-19 constitute a serious threat to public health, and that the provisions of a control order are necessary or expedient to prevent or contain the spread.

- Restrictions on movement remain one of the most draconian, intrusive measures a country has taken, reflective of Singapore as a nanny-state.
 - However, issues of enforcement remain prevalent.
- **Ecommerce & Corona:** As the COVID-19 pandemic rages on worldwide, a new digital normal seems to be emerging from the disruption to regular routines and behaviours. COVID-19 has similarly revealed the potential – and the limits – of Singapore’s online shopping sector.
 - Online grocery shopping is the fastest-growing slice of the pie, with Alibaba-backed RedMart dominating the scene and NTUC FairPrice continuing to invest in online platforms.
 - Many traditional small wet market grocers have taken to online channels to hawk products, conduct online auctions and even to carry out customer relation-building, for example, passing tips on how to prepare dishes using their products.
 - When the Disease Outbreak Response System Condition (DORSCON) level was raised to Orange, Singaporeans did not just flock to physical supermarkets, but also loaded virtual carts with groceries from online platforms.
 - Straits Times reported that RedMart’s weekly average number of orders tripled, while FairPrice said that demand for online orders exceeded that during the Lunar New Year period.
 - After authorities encouraged Singaporeans to purchase food and groceries online, Amazon Prime, FairPrice and Redmart have been swamped with orders, preventing them from providing enough delivery slots for online purchases.
 - There is also a good chance for the emergence of a “newer normal” where consumption habits become dualistic, where consumers continue to buy online even as they return to their old habits of tactile consumption.
- **Job security:**

- On Mar 26) the Ministry of Trade and Industry released data showing that for the first three months of this year, Singapore's economy contracted by 10.6 per cent from the previous quarter.
- The S\$48 billion Resilience Budget was announced to save jobs, help households cope with immediate costs and assist companies with cost and credit pressures.
 - According to reports, Singapore is bracing for a drop of between 25 and 30 per cent to tourist arrivals this year.
 - Big players have already announced pay cuts of between five and 15 per cent for senior management.
 - Other big companies are also exploring the following options: bonus cuts, wage and hiring freezes, and voluntary no-pay leave.
- The Resilience Budget delivered on Thursday by DPM Heng Swee Keat, may bring some relief in the form of the Government's co-funding 25 per cent of wages for local workers until the end of the year.
- It will go a long way in helping companies manage their cost pressures and thus jobs.
- **Evaluation:** Despite this Resilience Budget to alleviate cost pressures, and although companies in Singapore have been doing really well in holding out against cutting staff, certain sectors and businesses may have to reduce headcount eventually, as the pandemic continues to put pressures on businesses.
 - COVID-19 has starved many companies that depend on retail traffic from customers as more people are staying at home.
 - Businesses that are dependent on staying open to generate revenue like food and beverage outlets, engage in transactions that are upfront — paid via cash or card- and could be hampered by negative cash flow by a drop in consumer.
 - This is also the time for a cross-functional team — business, human resources and management — to assess how best to retain talent while belt-tightening, and how to tap on the two rescue packages to buffer operation costs.
- **Food security:**

- The agri-food industry will receive a S\$30 million boost to speed up the production of commonly consumed food items like eggs, vegetables and fish.
- Called the 30x30 Express grant, it is aimed at further strengthening Singapore's food security, as part of its goal of meeting 30 per cent of the country's nutritional needs with food produced locally by 2030.
- "The current COVID-19 situation underscores the importance of local food production, as part of Singapore's strategies to ensure food security," said the Ministry of the Environment and Water Resources (MEWR) and Singapore Food Agency (SFA) in a media release on April 8
- In addition to increasing the country's capabilities to produce food locally, the agencies said the move could also create more jobs for Singaporeans in the agri-food industry and help local small- and medium-sized enterprises. The latest efforts to increase local food production will be driven by a newly formed multi-agency taskforce led by Minister for the Environment and Water Resources Masagos Zulkifli.
- **Evaluation:** Whilst laudable, such an initiative remains small in scale and requires long-term cooperation between stakeholders to take effect. In reality, a large proportion of Singapore's food supply is contributed by its neighbouring partners. This would take decades to rectify.
- **Sg – better prepared for COVID-19 than SARS:**
 - (1) What has changed this time is that Singapore is now ranked as one of the top biotech and innovation locations globally – and that we are pulling above our weight to make a difference.
 - **Detecting the virus:** The Bioinformatics Institute at A*STAR supports the GISAID (Global Initiative on Sharing All Influenza Data) database, where genetic sequences of the COVID-19 virus are uploaded and shared.
 - Working closely with the National Centre for Infectious Diseases (NCID), scientists at Duke-NUS Medical School successfully cultured the COVID-19 virus just one week after it landed in Singapore on Jan 23, 2020.

- This group went on to become the first globally to develop a serological test for COVID-19, which detects antibodies produced by the body's immune response against the virus, setting the stage for rapid testing and population surveillance.
- (2) An A*STAR kit, jointly developed with Tan Tock Seng Hospital (TTSH), was deployed in public hospitals by early February, while 10,000 tests were shipped to support efforts in China
 - This will **enable doctors at the frontline to diagnose COVID-19 in their clinics without having to send samples to hospital laboratories.**
- (3) Given the high standards of care in our hospitals, as well as the tight network of public and university labs, Singapore offers advantages for companies to conduct drug development here.

Analysis of the Singapore Migration Worker COVID situation:

We deserve it: The current migration worker situation is reflective of a greater trend of Singapore's narcissism and elitism: Over the years, Singapore's history with migrant worker accommodation has seen a general apprehension towards housing migrant workers in the residential community.

- "The dormitories were like a time bomb waiting to explode," Singapore lawyer Tommy Koh wrote in a widely circulated Facebook post earlier this month. "The way Singapore treats its foreign workers is not First World but Third World"
- In 2008, more than 1,400 Serangoon Gardens residents signed a petition against a dormitory situated in their neighbourhood, which they handed to then National Development Minister Mah Bow Tan, citing "cleanliness" concerns and "cultural" differences as reasons against bringing dormitories closer to residential areas.
- The end result being that dormitories are constructed in a densely populated manner due to the shortage of available land.
- The key tenet is that Singaporeans employ a us-versus-them mindset - we want to enjoy the benefits of cheap and transient foreign labour, but are not prepared to bear the cost.
- A reflection of this neglect is evident - despite a surge in public discourse after the SMRT bus drivers' strike in 2012 and the Little India riot a year later, progress has "lagged behind expectations".

Employers are at fault:

There are about 200,000 migrant workers housed in 43 purpose-built dormitories around Singapore. These are licensed dormitories housing more than 1,000 workers each and are required to comply with the requirements under the Foreign Employee Dormitory Act (FEDA), such as providing facilities that include sick bays and isolation rooms. Dormitory operators are also required to draw contingency plans in case of a pandemic, such as providing arrangements for quarantine. Despite this, around 20 of the purpose-built dormitories - nearly half - flout the FEDA licensing requirement on average each year, Manpower Minister Josephine Teo revealed in Parliament on Monday on May 4 2020. The essential point being that employers of migrant workers do not themselves exercise sympathy in relation to the situation.

Post Covid: Questioning our reliance on low-cost foreign workers.

Singapore must reassess its whole relationship with migrant workers, especially its “addiction” to cheap migrant labour, and examine whether the lessons learnt from the explosion of COVID-19 cases in the workers’ dormitories could be used to implement meaningful changes.

- **Productivity:** The easy availability of foreign labour will reduce the incentives for companies to raise productivity.
 - “There is scope to reduce this reliance even further. By encouraging companies to rely less on foreign labour in their production processes, we can in fact nudge them to adopt smarter and less costly methods of production.”
 - For example, construction companies can focus on prefabricated prefinished volumetric construction (PPVC), whereby entire rooms are first prefinished and fitted out in factories with the use of automation and machinery, before being transported on-site for assembly. This reduces the requirement for foreign labour in construction industries, as these new construction methods “effectively transferred major portions of the work previously carried out on the construction sites into the factories”.
- The key consideration being that will the Singapore economy be able to cope with increased costs?
- **Cost considerations:** New and stricter guidelines that are likely to follow – i.e. less densely populated housing, better treatment and facilities would lead to housing to be more costly and not all contractors may be able to stomach this, the employers said. This is especially if they have long-term projects underway, some of which can last four to five years.
- **Efficiency considerations:** There are consequences in rethinking the social and economic impact on which Singapore is built, and relying less on foreign labour, he added. "Public transport and housing infrastructure will take longer time to build - HDB flats and MRT lines could take longer to come onstream."

Government's response to the migrant worker situation is laudable

With the renewed national attention on migrant workers, the Government has pledged to raise living standards in dormitories when the battle against COVID-19 is over.

- “By the end of next month (July), we expect about 70 to 80 per cent of the workers staying in the dormitories to be cleared. This means that they would have either recovered, or tested free of the virus” – Lawrence Wong noted in a July 11 2020 interview.
- Rapid segregation of infected workers to ensure that economy is still running:
 - About 12,000 of them are essential workers who have been moved out earlier from dormitories into government-provided accommodation facilities and have been working thus far. 20,000 workers were transferred to the government-provided accommodation facilities after recovering or testing negative.
- Implementation of QBDs: the Government aims to pilot the improved set of standards at temporary Quick Build Dormitories (QBDs) first, including more living space per resident, a smaller occupancy in each room, fewer workers sharing wet facilities, and more sick bay beds and isolation facilities.
- Inter-agency task force was set up on Apr 7 to provide support to foreign workers and dormitory employers.
 - In response to requests by dormitory operators and employers to have a way to check the work status of the foreign employees, the ITF and MOM, together with Defence Science and Technology Agency and Government Technology Agency, have created a new “AccessCode” feature on the SGWorkPass mobile app.
 - For a start, the colour status of the AccessCode takes into account three broad parameters:
 - Worker’s health status - they were tested positive earlier and discharged or have been tested negative;
 - Worker’s work status - the lead agencies (e.g. Ministry of Trade & Industry, Economic Development Board and Building & Construction Authority) have granted approval for his employer to resume business operations; and
 - Worker’s residence status - his dormitory or block is cleared, and his address is kept updated
 - This allows end-to-end tracking and management of the situation at hand.

GE2020: An analysis

Increased women representation in GE2020

GE2020 – a watershed moment for female politicians in the city-state

- A record 40 women are vying for seats in parliament, up from the 36 who contested the 2011 election and 35 in 2015. The ruling PAP, which until recently enjoyed a near-monopoly on political talent, is fielding 25 women among its 93 candidates, versus 20 five years ago
 - Several women who held senior military positions are contesting Friday's polls, including Gan Siow Huang, Singapore's first female general and a PAP candidate. Another of the ruling party's new stars is Mariam Jaafar, one of Boston Consulting Group's senior leaders in Southeast Asia
- There has been unprecedented substantive discussion of gender during this campaign. The Workers' Party manifesto, which dwells at length on issues like the gender pay gap and the need to compensate unpaid household labor, has been praised for its progressiveness. The PAP has dedicated at least two lengthy Facebook Live sessions to issues like violence against women and female participation in the economy
- **History:**
 - While Singaporean women have outnumbered men in higher education for some time, female political representation has lagged behind. The World Economic Forum's latest Global Gender Gap Index ranks Singapore 92nd for political empowerment, lower than South Korea and Indonesia. When the government named a 17-member task force to guide Singapore's post-coronavirus economic recovery, critics pointed out there were just two women.
 - Previously, female politicians have also faced online harassment with gendered language. When Tin Pei Ling, a millennial PAP lawmaker, first stood for parliament in 2011, a Facebook photo of her posing alongside a designer handbag drew much vitriol. (She was subsequently re-elected by a sizable margin.) Nicole Seah, who is now running for the Workers' Party, was previously mocked for tearing up while campaigning.

Structural notes on the Singapore political scene (Pro-PAP?)

Rights groups like ASEAN Parliamentarians for Human Rights have long-flagged various other election processes that they say disadvantage the opposition.

- (1) For example, Singapore's electoral divisions are revised regularly to reflect population growth and shifts. But the process is opaque and opposition figures have previously made allegations of gerrymandering.
 - Further the Elections Department reports directly to the office of the prime minister, who also appoints a group of civil servants that determines electoral boundaries. Those are often released just before a vote is called, which opposition lawmakers say gives them less time to come up with an effective strategy.

- "Gerrymandering is a real problem because you don't have an independent electoral commission, therefore nobody knows the basis for writing up the various constituencies
- (2) The prime minister can also call for an election, with presidential approval, at short notice, creating difficulties for the opposition to prepare. The campaigning period for the coming vote is just nine days.
- (3) The financial cost of running can also be a deterrent. Candidates must put up election deposits of S\$13,500 (\$9,675) to stand, compared to 500 pounds (\$623) in Britain, and they need to win more than one-eighth of total votes to get their deposit back. The minimum campaign period of just nine days is one of the shortest in the world, compared with at least 36 days in Canada and 33 days in Australia. Opinion polls are banned during election campaigns.
- (4) The mainstream local media - which has close ties to the government - generally supports the government and state policies even during an election, rights groups say. The PAP did not respond to a request for comment and its leaders have previously said press freedoms must be practiced with national interests in mind.
- (5) GRC system: Singapore inherited its "first-past-the-post system" from its British colonizers, allowing a candidate who secures the greatest number of votes to win office. In the 1980s, it introduced GRCs of four to six candidates — at least one of whom must come from outside the ethnic-Chinese majority, which comprises about three-quarters of the citizenry. The move, implemented to ensure a diverse Parliament without stoking racial divisions, has helped result in the government maintaining a lock on the legislature. This makes it harder for the opposition to field qualified teams of candidates.
- (6) POFMA; The PAP-dominated Parliament last year passed the Protection from Online Falsehoods and Manipulation Act (Pofma), which gives officials the power to request companies like Facebook Inc. to block pages if online platforms don't post a government-issued correction alongside the original article. While the ruling party has said the law is needed to fight against errant online information, Facebook has said the blocking orders are "severe and risk being misused to stifle voices and perspectives on the internet."
 - Chee Soon Juan, secretary-general of the Singapore Democratic Party, saw his party hit with a Pofma notice for comments made on the campaign trail. He's among several opposition members over the years to face libel and defamation cases: He was declared bankrupt after failing to pay S\$500,000 (\$350,000) for defaming PAP leaders during the 2001 election, and was only cleared to run later after paying a reduced sum.
 - "We're not just fighting against the ruling party," Chee told Bloomberg TV. "Understand that we're fighting against the entire state machinery."

Our dependence for skilled foreign workers are sound

Employment Passes allow companies to bring in foreign professionals to plug skills gaps and supply shortages, so as to attract and root high-value activities in Singapore. This is necessary to create and sustain a wide range of good jobs that meet Singaporeans' career aspirations.

- **The rationale:** For example, to develop our ICT and software industries, which require highly specialised skills and knowledge, global companies like Google, Grab, and Facebook need workers with the relevant skills and experience to fill all the jobs they create. There may not be enough Singapore citizens with these skills and experience to anchor these global companies' investment. Hence, Government should do as the previous generation did to anchor the electronics industry, which was to create the jobs in Singapore first, even if some of these higher-paying jobs went to foreigners initially, and to train Singapore citizens and upgrade their skills to eventually take on these higher-paying jobs.

Solutions to protect Singapore citizens: To ensure that Singapore citizens do not have their salaries undercut by foreigners, the Ministry of Manpower (MOM) requires Employment Pass applicants to meet salary thresholds, which are regularly updated taking reference from the salaries of locals with similar experience and seniority. For example, the Employment Pass minimum qualifying salary will be raised from \$3,600 to \$3,900 with effect from 1 May 2020. The salary thresholds for older and more experienced applicants will also be raised in tandem. For example, an EP applicant in his early 40s will need to earn around double the new minimum qualifying salary of \$3,900.

- MOM also requires employers to make jobs accessible to Singapore citizens, and recruit fairly based on merit. Under the Fair Consideration Framework (FCF), employers must advertise on MyCareersFuture.sg before they make an Employment Pass application.
- MOM also proactively identifies employers that are suspected to have discriminatory hiring practices, and places them on the FCF Watchlist. Their Employment Pass applications are closely scrutinised by MOM, and uncooperative employers have had their work pass privileges withdrawn.
- In January 2020, MOM strengthened the FCF by raising penalties across the board for all discrimination cases (including age, race, nationality and mental health condition). Employers that violate the Tripartite Guidelines on Fair Employment Practices (TGFEPP) will be barred from hiring new foreign workers and renewing existing foreign workers, for a minimum of 12 months up to a maximum of 24 months. MOM will also prosecute employers and key personnel who make false declarations on fair consideration. If convicted, they could face up to 2 years of imprisonment, fined up to \$20,000, or both.
- Members of the public who encounter workplace discrimination should report it to TAFEP. Beyond the employers, MOM will also take individual employees to task if they were involved in any unfair hiring practices, including revoking their work passes if they are foreigners.

Essay skills:

- (1) Be Keyword focused – identify key keywords in the question of which it is an independent variable.
 - Consider this 2019 A Levels question for example: **“Can fiction teach us anything meaningful about the real world?”**. Take a moment to try and identify the keywords before you read on.
 - The subject focus is of course “Fiction” and the claim is “teach us anything meaningful”. All examples will have to be related to fiction and you would have to **think about the different forms of fiction to provide comprehensive examples**: books, movies, games, myths etc. If you memorised some general essay about the arts, that would have been out of point because fiction is a very specific type of work among the arts.
 - Then, you will need to define “meaningful” and **think about the various definitions of it – how is it manifested? how do you know something is meaningful?** For e.g. it is about providing lessons, value , making an impact etc. But you have to be more specific since it is about “the real world”. We can say that fiction reflects real world problems happening around the world to raise awareness about them. From there, it teaches important lessons that we can take away.
- (2) Ensure your elaboration and content is persuasive.
 - Key question to ask yourself is – so what? If you can continue to ask yourself that when you read your essay, it is not clear and persuasive enough.
- (3) Have a concise and clear thesis statement: Your thesis statement should be the “umbrella” of which the body expands on.
 - A good thesis statement is specific, summarizing the points you are to make in the paragraph itself.

Bad	Good
Everyone should exercise.	Americans should add exercise to their daily morning routine because it not only keeps their bodies at a healthy weight but also reduces the risk of high blood pressure.

	- Here, we've made several specifications i.e. Americans (not everyone), the morning routine (not the evening), weight maintenance, and high blood pressure prevention. Your research actually becomes easier when you have very specific objectives.
The internet has improved the lives of many. - Again, while readers may agree with this and your statement may be true, how has the internet improved people's lives? Also, you should run your thesis statement past the "What's in it for me?" test. Why should readers care?	The internet serves as a means of expediently connecting people across the globe, fostering new friendships and an exchange of ideas that wouldn't have occurred prior to its inception. - While the internet offers a host of benefits, we're choosing to hone in on its ability to foster new friendships and exchange ideas. We'd also have to prove how this couldn't have happened prior to the internet's inception - and that is good. The tighter your focus, the better your paper.
Organ donors should be financially compensated.	Given the grueling surgery and lifelong changes they endure, kidney donors should be financially compensated for their act of self-sacrifice. - There are many forms of living organ donation. As with any good thesis, you want to get as specific as possible. Now, our stance is clear and the reader will understand that we're about to describe the grueling process of kidney donation as well as any forthcoming lifestyle changes.

All retirees should relocate to Florida.	Retirees should relocate to Florida, where 75% of Americans choose to settle, because you will afford yourself the opportunity to develop a wide array of friendships. - From here, you can introduce a paragraph on the importance of friendship and then cite studies or testimonials describing how people can discover these important new relationships.
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- (4) Use connective words for greater persuasive impact during sentences.

USAGE	CONNECTIVE WORDS
addition of ideas	and, also, besides, further, furthermore, too, moreover, in addition, then, of equal importance, equally important, another
time	next, afterward, finally, later, last, lastly, at last, now, subsequently, then, when, soon, thereafter, after a short time, the next week (month, day, etc.), a minute later, in the meantime, meanwhile, on the following day, at length, ultimately, presently
order or sequence	first, second, (etc.), finally, hence, next, then, from here on, to begin with, last of all, after, before, as soon as, in the end, gradually
space and place	above, behind, below, beyond, here, there, to the right (left), nearby, opposite, on the other side, in the background, directly ahead, along the wall, as you turn right, at the top, across the hall, at this point, adjacent to
to signal an example	for example, to illustrate, for instance, to be specific, such as, moreover, furthermore, just as important, similarly, in the same way
results	as a result, hence, so, accordingly, as a consequence, consequently, thus, since, therefore, for this reason, because of this
purpose	to this end, for this purpose, with this in mind, for this reason(s)

comparison	like, in the same manner (way), as so, similarly
contrast connectives	but, in contrast, conversely, however, still, nevertheless, nonetheless, yet, and yet, on the other hand, on the contrary, or, in spite of this, actually, in fact
to summarize or report	in summary, to sum up, to repeat, briefly, in short, finally, on the whole, therefore, as I have said, in conclusion, as you can see